

Render unto Chance

Numismatic Theology, Counterfeit Grace, and the Ethics of the Edge in the Cinema of Joel and Ethan Coen

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that the cinema of Joel and Ethan Coen constitutes a *numismatic theology*: a sustained and internally coherent inquiry into what becomes of transcendence once its face has been minted onto a coin, surviving only as currency (valuation), as chance (decision), and as effigy (the sovereign image). The coin is read not as one motif among many but as the master-object of the corpus, the hinge that joins Anton Chigurh's toss in *No Country for Old Men* (2007) to the 'whose image?' of Matthew 22 restaged in *Hail, Caesar!* (2016), the ransom buried in the snow of *Fargo* (1996), the counterfeit briefcase of *The Big Lebowski* (1998), the bribe and the record-club debt of *A Serious Man* (2009), and the two California gold pieces whose theft sets *True Grit* (2010) in motion.

Part One reconstructs the philosophical and theological originators of the corpus. The later Wittgenstein, subject of Ethan Coen's Princeton senior thesis, supplies the grammar of Coen action through the rule-following considerations, the private-language argument, and the 'beetle in the box', which the dissertation develops into a Wittgensteinian theory of the MacGuffin. The Hebrew Bible and its rabbinic interpreters supply the corpus's deep syntax: the lot (*goral*, *pur*), the hidden face (*hester panim*), the whirlwind of Job and the vapour (*hevel*) of Qoheleth, refracted through Rashi, Maimonides, Kafka, and Gershom Scholem's formula for a revelation possessing 'validity without significance'. A natural history of contingency, from Heraclitus, Aristotle, Lucretius, and Boethius through Pascal, Laplace, Peirce, and Heisenberg to Quentin Meillassoux, supplies its cosmology.

Part Two reads the films through the three faces of the coin. The obverse, or the Fix, is the domain in which sovereignty (Hobbes, Schmitt, Kantorowicz, Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor) labours to abolish chance. The reverse, or the Toss, is the domain in which subjects become Leibnizian monads deprived of pre-established harmony. The edge, or the Abiding, is the improbable third position occupied by the corpus's rare figures of grace. Part Three situates the Coens within a constellation of speculative, mythological, and philosophical fictions, among them Melville's doubloon, Hammett's Flitcraft parable, Borges's Zahir and 'Lottery in Babylon', Kafka, Lem, Dick, Vonnegut, Pynchon, DeLillo, Le Guin, Stoppard, Beckett, Cervantes, Homer, and the Grail cycle.

Part Four advances four original theses. Coen signs possess *fiat validity*: they circulate, bind, and kill without meaning, in a corpus produced entirely within the post-1971 regime of unbacked money. Coen pastiche is not Jamesonian 'blank parody' but *kenotic pastiche*, a Menardian re-inscription of emptied genres that converts inherited form into a site of attention. Coen comedy takes the shape of a *Purim-shpil*, a carnival of the hidden God in a

world of lots, oriented toward the rabbinic limit of not-knowing (*ad de-lo yada*). And the corpus elaborates an *ethics of the edge*, mapped onto Peirce's triad of tychism, anancism, and agapism, in which grace appears only as *counterfeit grace*: unbacked, unguaranteed, given by fiat, and for exactly that reason the only gift possible in a universe whose god is legal tender. Against the critical commonplaces of nihilism, condescension, and empty virtuosity, the dissertation concludes that the Coens are among the most rigorously theological artists of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries.

PREFATORY NOTE

on Corpus, Method, and Citation

The primary corpus comprises the eighteen features directed jointly by Joel and Ethan Coen between 1984 and 2018: *Blood Simple* (1984), *Raising Arizona* (1987), *Miller's Crossing* (1990), *Barton Fink* (1991), *The Hudsucker Proxy* (1994), *Fargo* (1996), *The Big Lebowski* (1998), *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* (2000), *The Man Who Wasn't There* (2001), *Intolerable Cruelty* (2003), *The Ladykillers* (2004), *No Country for Old Men* (2007), *Burn After Reading* (2008), *A Serious Man* (2009), *True Grit* (2010), *Inside Llewyn Davis* (2013), *Hail, Caesar!* (2016), and *The Ballad of Buster Scruggs* (2018). Until *The Ladykillers*, the directing credit was Joel's and the producing credit Ethan's, a division the brothers treated as a formality. The dissertation accordingly reads the signature 'Coen' as a single author-function in Michel Foucault's sense ('What Is an Author?', 1969), a principle of grouping rather than a biographical person, and it counts as part of that function the pseudonymous editor 'Roderick Jaynes', twice nominated for the Academy Award.

The secondary corpus comprises the screenplays written for other directors, among them Sam Raimi's *Crimewave* (1985) and Steven Spielberg's *Bridge of Spies* (2015, with Matt Charman); Ethan Coen's stories, verse, and plays; and the films the brothers made separately after 2018: Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth* (2021), and Ethan Coen's *Jerry Lee Lewis: Trouble in Mind* (2022), *Drive-Away Dolls* (2024), and *Honey Don't!* (2025), the last two written with Tricia Cooke. The corpus closes with *Honey Don't!*. Later work lies outside its frame, as does Noah Hawley's television series *Fargo* (2014–2024), which the brothers executive-produced but did not write.

Three classes of relation between the films and their sources are distinguished throughout. *Documented sources* are texts the films name, cite, or adapt: Homer, Hammett, Cain, Chandler, Portis, McCarthy, Jack London, Shelley, Lew Wallace, the Book of Job, Rashi, Heisenberg, Herbert Marcuse. *Biographical proximities* are bodies of thought demonstrably near the makers: Wittgenstein, the subject of Ethan Coen's undergraduate thesis, and the Jewish milieu of the brothers' Minnesota childhood. *Elective affinities*, a term Goethe borrowed from chemistry, Weber from Goethe, and Michael Löwy (*Redemption and Utopia*, 1988) refined into a method for tracing structural kinships between Jewish messianism and modern thought, name homologies that claim no influence: Pascal, Boethius, Peirce, Levinas, Meillassoux. The distinction matters because the dissertation's claims concern the films' thinking, not their makers' reading. With Stanley Cavell (*The World Viewed*, 1971)

and Stephen Mulhall (*On Film*, 2002), it holds that films can philosophise in their own medium, so that a correspondence between a sequence and a philosophical text is evidence of convergent thought rather than of transmission.

Scripture is quoted from the Authorized (King James) Version, whose cadences the brothers' *True Grit* made part of the corpus; the Vulgate is cited where its Latin matters. Wittgenstein is cited by section (*PI* §) and numbered proposition (*TLP*); Pascal by Lafuma number; Heraclitus by Diels–Kranz fragment; the Babylonian Talmud by tractate and folio; Maimonides' *Guide of the Perplexed* by part and chapter. Film dialogue is quoted sparingly and briefly. Longer exchanges are paraphrased, and no claim to verbatim fidelity is made beyond the short phrases set in quotation marks.

UN COUP DE DÉS

JAMAIS

n'abolira

LE HASARD.

The lot is cast into the lap; but the whole disposing thereof is of the LORD.

— Proverbs 16:33

— Stéphane Mallarmé, 1897

INTRODUCTION

The Coin and the Face

I

Two Scenes

The Coen corpus turns on two scenes nine years apart, and the argument of this dissertation is contained in their juxtaposition. In the first, set in a West Texas filling station in 1980, Anton Chigurh asks a proprietor guilty of nothing worse than small talk what is the most he has ever lost on a coin toss. The question converts conversation into theology. The coin, Chigurh explains, was minted in 1958 and has travelled twenty-two years to reach this counter; the proprietor has been staking his life on it all along without knowing it; he must now 'call it'. The man calls heads and wins, and is warned not to pocket the coin, lest it mingle with the others and become merely a coin, which, Chigurh concedes, is all it is.

The scene stages in a single transaction the three operations a coin can perform. It values, being legal tender on a counter of small change. It decides, since its fall will determine whether a man lives. And it inscribes, bearing the effigy of the republic that guarantees its

worth. Valuation, decision, and inscription are ordinarily distinct: we do not spend coins to decide things, and we do not toss coins to learn who rules us. On a counter between two strangers in 1980 the three operations have become indistinguishable, and the terror of the scene lies in the proprietor's dawning recognition that the object he has handled all his life as money has always also been a lot and an icon.

The second scene inverts the first. In *Hail, Caesar!* (2016), set at the fictional Capitol Pictures in 1951, the studio's fixer, Eddie Mannix, convenes a rabbi, a Catholic priest, a Protestant minister, and an Eastern Orthodox patriarch to vet the depiction of Christ in the studio's prestige spectacle, *Hail, Caesar! A Tale of the Christ*. The spectacle's subtitle borrows Lew Wallace's *Ben-Hur* (1880). The film's title borrows the salutation owed to the figure whose image Jesus asked to see on the tribute denarius before pronouncing that what is Caesar's be rendered to Caesar and what is God's to God (Matthew 22:15–22). The pericope concerns the same three operations. The denarius is tribute; the question put to Jesus is a trap whose answer will decide his fate; and the coin's *eikon* raises the question of sovereignty against the background of the creature's own status as image (Genesis 1:27). The coin bears Caesar's face, the person bears God's, and that is why each is owed to its owner.

Between Matthew's coin and Chigurh's lies the problem the brothers spent four decades elaborating: what becomes of the God whose image the creature bears once the only image left in circulation is Caesar's, and once Caesar's image, tossed, decides. This dissertation names the films' response *numismatic theology*. The term designates neither a doctrine the Coens hold nor an allegory they encode. It names a structure their films display with a consistency no accident explains: a world in which the face (Hebrew *panim*, Greek *prosopon*) through which transcendence once addressed the creature has been minted, so that it survives only as currency, as chance, and as effigy. In such a world theology is not abolished. It is coined.

II

The State of the Question

Four critical paradigms have organised the reception of the Coens, and each has identified a symptom of numismatic theology while missing its structure. The first, which may be called the nihilism thesis, takes seriously a cosmos of arbitrary violence and unrewarded virtue and asks whether anything in it holds value. It animated a long journalistic complaint about the brothers' supposed condescension toward their characters, and it supplied much of the philosophical agenda of the essays collected in Mark T. Conard's *The Philosophy of the Coen Brothers* (2009), which canvass the corpus for its engagements with nihilism, existentialism, and the possibility of meaning. The nihilism thesis notices that values in the Coen world are unstable. It does not notice that their instability is specifically monetary. Values in these films

are not abolished but devalued, inflated, counterfeited, and exchanged, which is a different fate and requires a different philosophy.

The second paradigm, the pastiche thesis, enlists the brothers as exemplary postmodernists. Fredric Jameson's account of pastiche as 'blank parody', a neutral mimicry of dead styles without parody's satiric impulse, and of the 'nostalgia film' as a symptom of the cultural logic of late capitalism (Jameson 1991), seemed written for directors whose filmography reads as a tour of American genres from screwball to western. R. Barton Palmer's monograph (2004) situates the brothers within these debates on postmodern authorship with particular care. The pastiche thesis notices that Coen forms are emptied. It does not notice that the emptying is kenotic rather than blank: that the vessel is preserved precisely so that its emptiness may be attended to.

The third paradigm, the genre thesis, treats the corpus as a revisionist anthology, a reading made explicit in the subtitle of Jeffrey Adams's *The Cinema of the Coen Brothers: Hard-Boiled Entertainments* (2015). It notices that the films anthologise. It does not ask what principle of selection governs the anthology, or why noir, the western, the gangster film, the screwball comedy, and the Hollywood satire should be the genres chosen. The answer, developed in Part Two, is that these are the American genres of money, chance, and sovereignty.

The fourth paradigm, the theological thesis, takes the brothers' religious material seriously. It ranges from homiletic readings such as Cathleen Falsani's *The Dude Abides: The Gospel According to the Coen Brothers* (2009) to a substantial literature on *A Serious Man* as Jewish theodicy. It notices that God is silent. It tends, however, to treat *A Serious Man* as the exception in an otherwise secular oeuvre rather than as what this dissertation takes it to be: the corpus's Rosetta stone, the one film in which the grammar of the others is spelled out in its original script. Beyond the academy, a fifth formation deserves notice: the quasi-religious afterlife of *The Big Lebowski*, from the Lebowski Fest (inaugurated in 2002) to Dudeism (founded in 2005), documented in Edward Comentale and Aaron Jaffe's *The Year's Work in Lebowski Studies* (2009). The dissertation treats that afterlife not as a curiosity but as evidence that the films generate religious forms in the act of emptying them.

III

An Economist and an Art Historian

A biographical conjunction may be recorded, provided it is not asked to bear weight. Joel (b. 1954) and Ethan (b. 1957) Coen grew up in St. Louis Park, Minnesota, the sons of Edward Coen, an economist at the University of Minnesota, and Rena Neumann Coen, an art historian at St. Cloud State University. The coin is the one object in which a father's discipline and a mother's meet: value and image, quantity and face, the general equivalent and the effigy. In deference to W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's strictures on intention

(1946) and to Foucault's dissolution of the author, the dissertation draws no inference from this. It would nonetheless be a strange scruple to suppress it.

Ethan Coen went on to study philosophy at Princeton, to which he transferred, reportedly drawn by the strength of its philosophy department. His senior thesis, 'Two Views of Wittgenstein's Later Philosophy' (1979), a short essay, was supervised by Raymond Geuss, whose first book, *The Idea of a Critical Theory* (1981), became an influential English-language account of the Frankfurt School's conception of critique. The conjunction is suggestive for Chapter Four, where *Hail, Caesar!* seats Herbert Marcuse in a Malibu study group, though nothing in this dissertation claims it as influence. The thesis was written, too, in a department to which Saul Kripke had been appointed in 1977, in the years in which Kripke was developing the sceptical reading of the rule-following considerations later published as *Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language* (1982). Whether the thesis engaged Kripke is not known to this study, and nothing below depends on it. Joel Coen studied film at New York University. The brothers' first feature, *Blood Simple*, took its title from Dashiell Hammett.

IV

Seven Propositions

The argument may be stated in seven propositions, numbered in homage to the *Tractatus*, whose author presides over Chapter One.

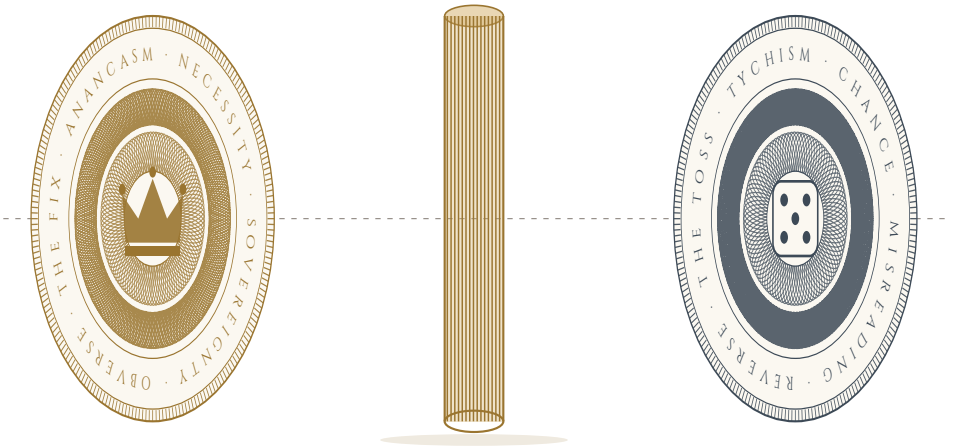
Proposition One. The Coen world is all that is the case, and what is the case is, in the last instance, decided. The films' worlds are not lawless. They are densely regulated by codes of honour, procedure, genre, and faith; but every regularity in them terminates in a decision the regularity cannot itself supply, and the films' characteristic instrument for representing that decision is a toss.

Proposition Two. The face through which transcendence once addressed the creature has been minted, and it survives as the effigy on a coin. The divine face is hidden (Deuteronomy 31:18); the face of the other is appraised rather than encountered; and the only face reliably in circulation is the sovereign's, struck in metal and backed by decree.

Proposition Three. The coin performs three operations, valuation, decision, and inscription, and in the Coen world they have become indistinguishable. What is worth something is what has been decided; what has been decided bears the sovereign's image; and the sovereign's image is worth only what it will buy.

Proposition Four. Signs in this world possess validity without significance. The formula is Gershom Scholem's, coined for Kafka (Chapter Two). Coen signs bind, circulate, and kill, but they do not mean, and the films' great set pieces of interpretation, from the Hebrew letters on a gentile's teeth to the cryptic 'DLR' in a murdered trooper's ticket book, dramatise the gap between a sign's authority and its content.

Proposition Five · Peirce's three modes of evolution



OBVERSE
the Fix
anancasm · necessity

Miller's Crossing
The Hudsucker Proxy
Barton Fink
Hail, Caesar!
No Country for Old Men
The Tragedy of Macbeth

EDGE
the Abiding
agapism · love

The Big Lebowski
O Brother, Where Art Thou?
Inside Llewyn Davis
Raising Arizona
True Grit
The Ballad of Buster Scruggs

REVERSE
the Toss
tychism · chance

Blood Simple
Fargo
Burn After Reading
The Man Who Wasn't There

FIG. 1 The three surfaces of the coin (Proposition Five). Obverse, edge and reverse correspond to the Fix, the Abiding and the Toss, and to Peirce's anancastic, agapastic and tychastic modes; beneath each, the films Part Two reads under that face.

Proposition Five. Every coin has three surfaces: obverse, reverse, and edge. The obverse is the Fix, sovereignty's attempt to abolish chance by rigging outcomes. The reverse is the Toss, chance experienced as the misreading of signs by subjects who cannot see one another. The edge is the Abiding, the improbable third outcome in which a value declines to be decided. The three correspond to Charles Sanders Peirce's three modes of cosmic evolution: anancastic, tychastic, and agapastic.

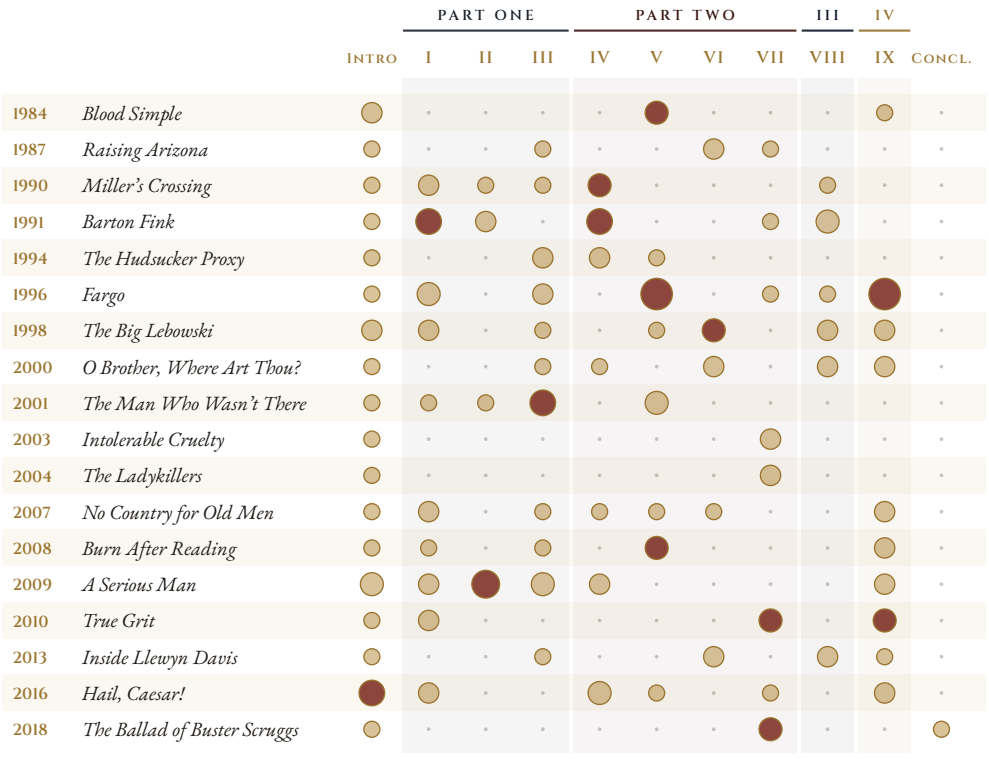
Proposition Six. In a world whose god is legal tender, grace can only be counterfeit: unbacked, unguaranteed, given by fiat. The films are themselves such coins. Their notorious irony is the declaration of their counterfeit status, and that declaration, far from cancelling the gift, is the condition of its being given.

Proposition Seven. Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must abide.

V

Plan of the Work

Part One, ‘Genealogies of the Coin’, comprises three chapters on originators. Chapter One reads the corpus through the later Wittgenstein: rule-following and its bedrock, the language-games of Minnesota, Texas, and Culver City, the beetle in the box as the logic of the MacGuffin, the fly-bottle as the shape of the Coen trap, and the hinges whose rusting Sheriff Bell mourns. Chapter Two descends to the corpus’s Hebrew substrate: the biblical lot, the hidden face, Purim, Job, Qoheleth, Rashi’s prohibition of divination, Maimonides, Kafka, Scholem, and the Lurianic contraction of God, with *A Serious Man* as its central text. Chapter Three writes a natural history of the toss from Heraclitus’s child-king to Meillassoux’s hyper-chaos. It closes with the physics of coin-tossing, which supplies the dissertation’s least expected datum: the measurable probability of the edge.



Citations of each title (italicised) per chapter of this study; the darkest disc marks the chapter in which a film is principally read.

FIG. 2 Where the corpus is read. The eighteen joint features against the chapters of this study; disc area grows with the number of times a title is cited. The bands mark the four Parts.

Part Two, 'The Three Faces', reads the films. Chapter Four treats the obverse: sovereignty and the Fix in *Miller's Crossing*, *The Hudsucker Proxy*, *Barton Fink*, *Hail, Caesar!*, *No Country for Old Men*, and Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth*. Chapter Five treats the reverse: the epistemology of noir in *Blood Simple*, *Fargo*, *Burn After Reading*, and *The Man Who Wasn't There*, with a coda on the Coens and David Lynch. Chapters Six and Seven treat the edge. Chapter Six follows the figures of abiding and uselessness through *The Big Lebowski*, *O Brother, Where Art Thou?*, *Inside Llewyn Davis*, and *Raising Arizona*. Chapter Seven follows the ledger and the gift through *True Grit* and *The Ballad of Buster Scruggs*, and the comedies of the con through *Intolerable Cruelty*, *The Ladykillers*, and the studio schemes of *Hail, Caesar!*.

Part Three, 'Constellations', comprises a single comparative chapter (Chapter Eight) that places the corpus among speculative, mythological, and philosophical fictions of chance, money, and providence. Part Four, 'Render unto Chance', synthesises the argument into a theory (Chapter Nine). The Conclusion reads the brothers' divergence after 2018 as the separation of the coin's two faces.



PART ONE

Genealogies of the Coin

CHAPTER ONE
Bedrock, Beetles, and the Fly-Bottle

CHAPTER TWO
Lots, Whirlwinds, and the Hidden Face

CHAPTER THREE
A Natural History of the Toss



Not how the world is, is the mystical, but that it is.

— Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* 6.44 (trans. C. K. Ogden, 1922)

CHAPTER ONE

Bedrock, Beetles, and the Fly-Bottle

Wittgenstein and the Grammar of the Coen World

1.1

A Grammarian's Cinema

The Coens' Wittgensteinianism is grammatical rather than thematic. Their films rarely mention philosophy, the one extended exception, a defence lawyer's courtroom Heisenberg, being physics, and nothing in them resembles the philosophical set piece of a Bergman or a Malick. What they share with the later Wittgenstein is a method: the patient survey of how words and acts are used within a form of life, attended by the conviction that the problems which torment their characters arise when language 'goes on holiday' (*PI* §38), when an expression is detached from the practice that gives it sense. The brothers' famously laconic interviews belong to the same method. Asked what their films mean, they decline, and the declining has the structure of Tractarian silence: what can be shown cannot be said (*TLP* 4.1212), and whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent (*TLP* 7).

Their irony behaves like the ladder of *TLP* 6.54, an instrument the viewer climbs and then discards. The films' ironic distance is not their final position. It is the means by which the viewer is brought to a place where irony no longer applies.

Three Wittgensteinian figures organise the corpus. The first is the rule-follower at bedrock, who acts on a rule when justifications have run out. The second is the beetle in the box, an object whose content drops out of the language-game in which it nonetheless plays an indispensable role. The third is the fly in the fly-bottle, the agent trapped in a confusion whose shape he cannot see. Each maps onto a recurrent structure of Coen narrative, and each, it will be argued, already encodes the numismatic problem.

1.2

Bedrock

The rule-following considerations (*PI* §§185–242) culminate in a paradox: no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with it (§201). Wittgenstein's response is not a theory but a description of practice. Obeying a rule is a custom, an institution (§199). When justifications are exhausted one has reached bedrock, the spade is turned, and one is inclined to say only that this is simply what one does (§217). Kripke's sceptical reading radicalised the paradox into the claim that no fact about an individual constitutes his meaning one rule rather than another, and proposed a 'sceptical solution' grounded in the assertibility conditions of a community.

The Coen corpus is populated by bedrock rule-followers, and its moral topography can be drawn by distinguishing the rules they follow. Walter Sobchak in *The Big Lebowski* is its purest specimen. A convert to Judaism for the sake of a wife who has since divorced him, he keeps the Sabbath with a rigour he cannot justify and does not try to: he will not drive, handle money, or bowl on Shabbos. When an opponent's toe crosses the foul line, he draws a pistol to enforce the scoring, reminding the room that this is bowling and there are rules. Walter is all bedrock and no justification. He observes the halakhah of a faith not his by birth or belief, and enforces the regulations of a league with an inquisitor's zeal; he is the comic form of §217, the spade turned against a foundation that is not there. Marge Gunderson in *Fargo* and Mattie Ross in *True Grit* follow rules of another kind, procedural and legal, as instruments of attention and justice: Marge's routine questions and her unbidden return to a car dealership; Mattie's contracts, her threats of litigation, her invocation of an absent attorney, J. Noble Daggett. Johnny Caspar opens *Miller's Crossing* by invoking 'ethics', by which he means the rule that a fixed fight should stay fixed. Anton Chigurh, the corpus's most articulate rule-follower, takes as his maxim the absolute keeping of his word.

Chigurh's encounter with Carson Wells condenses the paradox. Wells, a bounty hunter who has followed his professional rules into a hotel room where he is about to die, is asked a question of pure Wittgensteinian grammar: if the rule he followed brought him to this,

'of what use was the rule?' The question names the gap between a rule and its applications that §201 uncovers and that no further rule can close. Chigurh's own answer is the coin. When rules run out, when the question of whom to kill cannot be settled by any principle he acknowledges, he submits the decision to a toss. The coin is his sceptical solution.

The solution, however, is private, and here the corpus reaches its most precise philosophical moment. Wittgenstein's argument against a private language (*PI* §§243–315) observes that a rule only one person could check is no rule at all: in such a case whatever is going to seem right to me is right, which means only that here we cannot talk about 'right' (§258). Kripke's community has no member but Chigurh; the coin's verdicts answer to no criterion but his acceptance of them. When Carla Jean Moss, whose husband has been killed at an El Paso motel (by cartel gunmen, the film implies), refuses at the film's end to call the toss, telling him in substance that the coin has no say and that the choice is his alone, she performs the private-language argument in a Texas bedroom. Her refusal does not save her life: Chigurh kills her off screen, and the film shows only his exit from the house and his inspection of the soles of his boots. It does something the film treats as more important: it denies the coin the status of a rule, and so returns to Chigurh the responsibility the coin was minted to absorb.

1.3

Forms of Life

If rules give out at bedrock, what holds a world together is what Wittgenstein called a form of life (*Lebensform*), the shared repertoire of practices within which words have their use (*PI* §§19, 23, 241). The Coens are among cinema's most exacting ethnographers of forms of life, and their dialogue functions as a sequence of audible language-games. *Fargo*'s Minnesotan is dominated by what Bronisław Malinowski called phatic communion (1923) and Roman Jakobson the phatic function (1960): utterances whose purpose is to maintain contact rather than to convey information. The 'yah's and 'you betcha's of Brainerd are the medium of Marge's decency, a practice of courtesy that holds the social bond under strain, and also the medium of Jerry Lundegaard's evasions, since phatic speech can sustain contact while emptying it of content. *True Grit*'s diction, faithful to Charles Portis's novel (1968), all but abolishes contractions. The formality is not period ornament but an audible form of life, a Protestant frontier on which speech is a species of contract and every sentence is uttered as though under oath. *Miller's Crossing* speaks a hard-boiled argot derived from Hammett, in which every question about 'the rumpus' is a feint. *Barton Fink*'s playwright speaks the Popular Front idiom of the 'common man' with a sincerity the film exposes as deafness: he professes to write for the man he will not let finish a sentence.

Hail, Caesar! stages the collision of forms of life as phonetic farce. Hobie Doyle, a singing cowboy cast against type in a drawing-room drama, cannot deliver the line 'Would that it

were so simple' in the cadence his director, Laurence Laurentz, demands. The comedy is Wittgensteinian to the letter. The sentence's meaning lies in its use; its use belongs to a form of life in which Hobie does not live; and no drilling can transfer the use without the life. Hobie understands the words perfectly. What he cannot do is mean them in that way.

The Dude is the corpus's most radical case. His idiolect is largely borrowed: he repeats George H. W. Bush's televised 'This aggression will not stand' as though it were his own conviction, and recycles the phrases of nearly every interlocutor he meets. Mikhail Bakhtin would call this heteroglossia, the orchestration of socially stratified voices ('Discourse in the Novel', 1934–35). Wittgenstein would see in it a demonstration that there is no private language, that even the most idiosyncratic speaker speaks a public tongue. The Dude owns almost no word he utters, and his serenity seems to depend on that dispossession.

1.4

The Beetle in the Box: A Theory of the Coen MacGuffin

Wittgenstein's most famous thought experiment imagines that everyone has a box with something in it called a 'beetle'. No one can look into anyone else's box, and everyone says he knows what a beetle is only by looking at his own. The thing in the box, Wittgenstein concludes, has no place in the language-game at all, not even as a something, for the box might be empty: it cancels out, whatever it is (*PI* §293). The argument targets a picture of sensation-words as names of private objects. Its formal structure describes with uncanny precision the device Alfred Hitchcock called the MacGuffin, the thing the characters pursue and the audience disregards (Truffaut 1966).

The Coen corpus is a museum of beetle-boxes. In *Barton Fink*, Charlie Meadows leaves in the playwright's keeping a box roughly the size of a human head, which Barton never opens and which accompanies him into the film's final frame on a beach. In *Fargo*, the ransom disappears into a snowbank, marked by an ice scraper beside an endless row of identical fence posts, and is never recovered. In *The Big Lebowski*, the briefcase of ransom money contains the Dude's dirty laundry. In *No Country for Old Men*, a satchel of two million dollars circulates through the film and its final fate is withheld. In *Burn After Reading*, the computer disc that two gym employees mistake for raw intelligence contains the draft of a disgraced analyst's vain memoir. In *Hail, Caesar!*, a suitcase of ransom money goes into the Pacific as a defecting star boards a Soviet submarine. In *A Serious Man*, Arthur Gopnik's Mentaculus, a notebook purporting to map the probabilities of the universe, is shown only in glimpses of illegible diagrams. In each case the content either cancels out (it is never shown), proves worthless (laundry, a memoir), or is lost (snow, sea).

The first of these boxes is not empty by implication. The detectives who come looking for Charlie identify him as Karl 'Madman' Mundt, a killer who takes his victims' heads; Audrey Taylor, the secretary who has been writing much of W. P. Mayhew's fiction under his

A MUSEUM OF BEETLE-BOXES

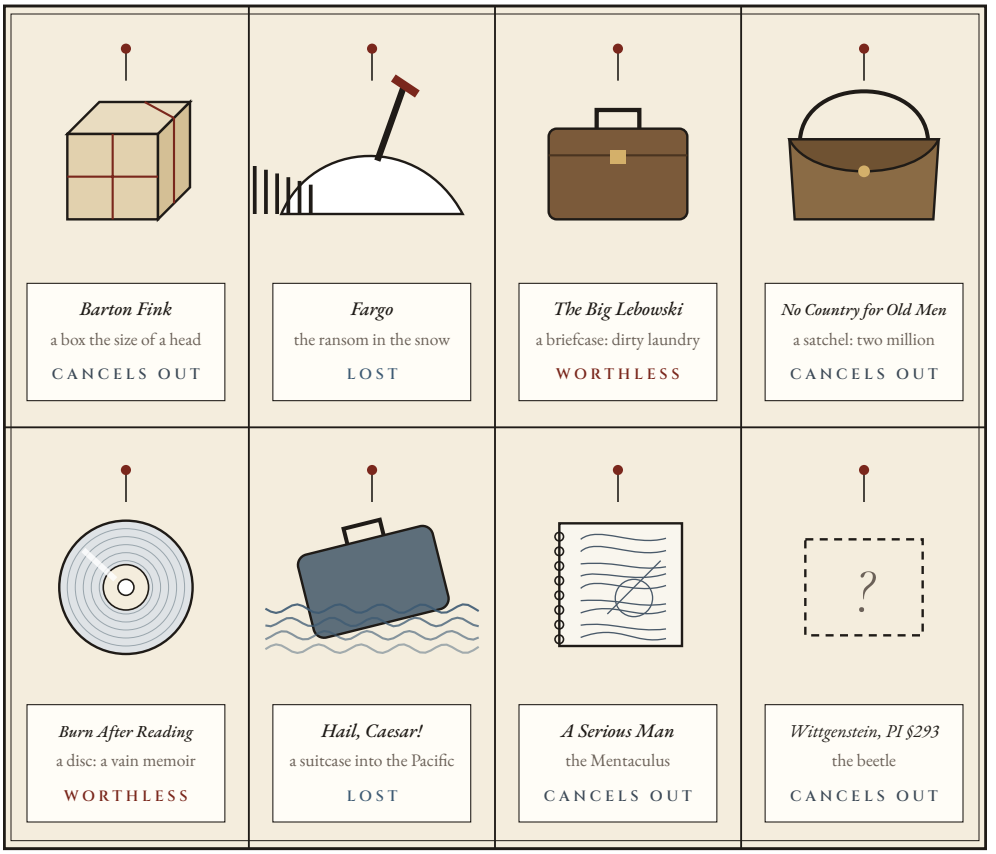


FIG. 3 A museum of beetle-boxes. Seven MacGuffins of the corpus, filed by the fate of their contents (cancelled out, worthless, lost), beside the box of *Philosophical Investigations* §293, whose content cancels out, whatever it is.

name, has been murdered in Barton's bed, the film strongly implies by Charlie; and the box is therefore widely taken to hold her head, a reading the film neither confirms nor refutes. W. P. Mayhew, too, is later found murdered and beheaded. The implication sharpens the theory that follows. What cancels out of the game is, by inference, the remains of a murdered woman whose authorship had already been counterfeited under a famous man's signature. In *Barton Fink*, both the work and the worker circulate under another's name, and both the man whose name was on the books and the woman who wrote them are beheaded.

The Coen MacGuffin thus differs from Hitchcock's in a decisive respect. Hitchcock's is indifferent to the audience because it is a device for generating suspense; its emptiness is a formal convenience. The Coens' is indifferent in Wittgenstein's sense: its content cancels out of the game in which it is traded. The films then draw the moral corollary that Wittgen-

stein, writing about sensations, had no occasion to draw. People die for what cancels out. The beetle-box is a coin in the sense Chapter Nine develops: an object whose function in exchange is independent of its intrinsic content, and which binds and kills by circulation alone. The Conclusion returns to Barton's box, which the brothers' separate careers would at last, in a manner of speaking, open.

Wittgenstein himself supplied the bridge from the beetle to the coin. Warning against the picture of meaning as an object for which a word stands, he set the money and the cow it can buy against money and its use (*PI* §120). Ferdinand de Saussure had used the same figure in the *Cours de linguistique générale* (1916): a five-franc coin has value because it can be exchanged for something dissimilar, a quantity of bread, and compared with something similar, a one-franc piece or a dollar, and linguistic value is constituted in the same double way. Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) described money as the purest instrument, the absolute means that becomes an end in itself. The Coen MacGuffin stands where the three accounts meet: a sign whose value is its use, a token whose worth is purely relational, an instrument that has become the object of desire.

1.5

The Fly-Bottle

Asked what his aim in philosophy was, Wittgenstein answered: to show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle (*PI* §309). The image figures confusion as entrapment in a transparent vessel whose walls the confused agent cannot see. *Barton Fink* is the corpus's literal fly-bottle. The Hotel Earle, whose stationery promises 'A Day or a Lifetime', is a sealed and sweating container. Its wallpaper peels and weeps paste, its corridors are lined with the paired shoes of unseen guests, and its resident mosquito feeds on Barton and on the corpse that appears in his bed. Barton's confusion is the philosopher's: a picture holds him captive (*PI* §115). He believes he possesses a privileged inner life, 'the life of the mind', from which he can speak for a common man he never hears. Charlie, who is that common man and a serial killer, ends the argument by running down a burning corridor with a shotgun, roaring that he will show him the life of the mind. The film does not show the fly the way out. In its final scene Barton walks onto a beach and finds there the woman from the picture above his desk, posed as in the picture. He has not escaped the bottle. He has entered the image on its wall.

The structure recurs across the corpus. Larry Gopnik in *A Serious Man* cannot exit a bureaucracy of rabbis, lawyers, tenure committees, and record clubs whose walls he cannot see; Llewyn Davis cannot exit a week that ends where it began; Ed Crane in *The Man Who Wasn't There* cannot exit a courtroom whose procedures yield verdicts unrelated to events. The Coens' relation to Wittgenstein's therapeutic aim is therefore inverse and complementary. Wittgenstein sought to dissolve philosophical problems by exposing them as confusions; the Coens show the bottle and decline to dissolve it, on the evident ground

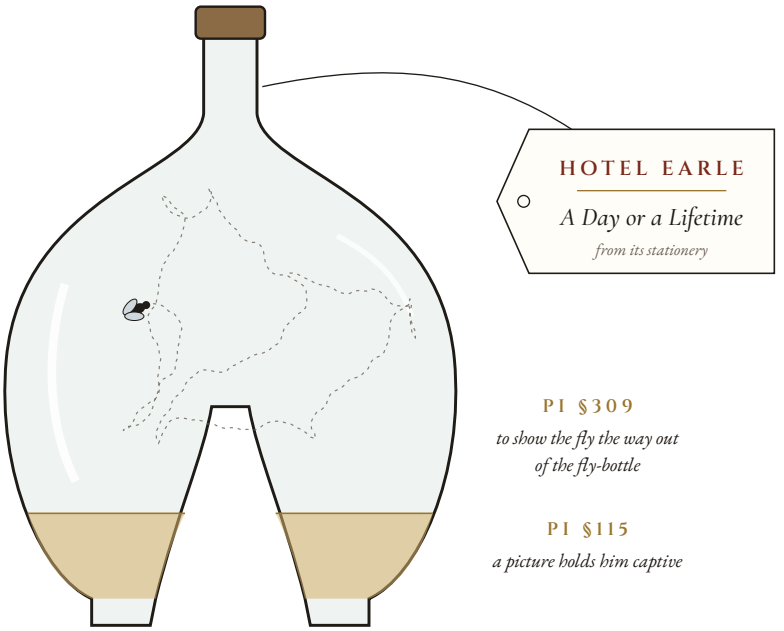


FIG. 4 The fly-bottle. Wittgenstein's image of confusion as a transparent trap, here with its fly's wandering course. *Barton Fink*'s Hotel Earle is the corpus's literal fly-bottle, and the film does not show the way out.

that these confusions are not philosophers' errors but the conditions of a life. The way out, where there is one, is never epistemic. It is ethical or comic, and it is found at the edge.

1.6

Hinges, Rituals, and Absolute Safety

Three further texts complete the grammar. In *On Certainty* (1969), Wittgenstein describes the propositions that stand fast for us as hinges on which our questions and doubts turn (§341): not conclusions reached but the frame within which reaching conclusions is possible. *No Country for Old Men* is an elegy for a hinge-system. Sheriff Ed Tom Bell's monologues, which open and close the film, mourn not a lost set of beliefs but the lost frame within which beliefs about crime, punishment, and decency could be held. The 'country' of the title is less Texas than the hinge-system itself, the inherited certainties that made it possible to recognise an act as evil, to anticipate it, and to answer it. When Bell visits his uncle Ellis, a crippled former lawman living among cats, the old man tells him that what he faces is nothing new, that the country has always been hard on people, and that to suppose

it is all waiting on him is vanity. Ellis's word is the King James rendering of Qoheleth's *hevel*, and Chapter Two takes him at his word.

In his 'Remarks on Frazer's *Golden Bough*' (written from 1931, published 1967), Wittgenstein objected that Frazer misread magical rites as primitive science, as mistaken hypotheses about causation, when they are expressions, like kissing a picture of the beloved, which no one supposes will affect the beloved. The Coen corpus is saturated with ritual in exactly this sense: bowling leagues, bar mitzvahs, haircuts, daily confession, the scattering of ashes, the eating of a contract. Critics who find these rituals absurd because they achieve nothing commit Frazer's error. Walter's eulogy for Donny, which wanders into Vietnam before he shakes the ashes from a coffee can into a wind that blows them back over the Dude, achieves nothing and expresses everything. It is a rite in which grief, failure, and fidelity are performed in the only vocabulary the mourner owns.

Finally, the 'Lecture on Ethics' (delivered 1929, published 1965) describes two experiences Wittgenstein takes to point toward absolute value: wonder at the existence of the world, and the experience of feeling absolutely safe, safe whatever happens. Both, he argues, are nonsense when put into words, and the nonsense is their essence. Two Coen protagonists embody these experiences without articulating them. Marge Gunderson, driving her prisoner to Brainerd in the film's last car scene, tells him there is more to life than a little money and that it is a beautiful day. Her sentence is the most elementary form of wonder that the world is (*TLP* 6.44), offered to a man who has just killed his accomplice with an axe and fed the body into a wood chipper. And the Dude abides: the verb names, as nearly as English can, the condition of being safe whatever happens.

Wittgenstein thus supplies the grammar of the Coen world: the bedrock at which rules give out, the forms of life within which words have use, the beetle-boxes for which people kill, the bottles from which no philosophy releases them, the hinges whose rusting the old mourn, and the rare figures who live in wonder and safety. A grammar, however, presupposes a language, and the language of the Coen world has an older and more specific source.



Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind.

— Job 38:1

CHAPTER TWO

Lots, Whirlwinds, and the Hidden Face

Hebrew Scripture, Rabbinic Hermeneutics, and A Serious Man

2.1

The Lot

The Hebrew Bible is the first literature to make a toss the medium of providence. The lot (*goral*) apportions the land among the tribes (Numbers 26:55–56; Joshua 18–19). On the Day of Atonement the high priest casts lots over two goats, one for the LORD and one for Azazel, so that chance designates which animal dies and which carries the people's sins into the wilderness (Leviticus 16:7–10). Jonah's shipmates cast lots to learn on whose account the storm has come upon them, and the lot falls on Jonah (Jonah 1:7). Haman casts the *pur* to fix the day on which the Jews of Persia will be destroyed, and the festival

commemorating their deliverance takes its name, Purim, from his lots (Esther 3:7; 9:24–26). In the New Testament, soldiers cast lots for the garments of the crucified (Matthew 27:35), and the apostles fill Judas's place by lot (Acts 1:26). Behind these narratives stands the oracle of the Urim and Thummim, borne in the high priest's breastplate (Exodus 28:30), whose second term shares its root, *t-m-m*, with *tamim*, 'whole', 'simple', 'perfect'.

The theology of the lot is condensed in a single verse: 'The lot is cast into the lap; but the whole disposing thereof is of the LORD' (Proverbs 16:33). The verse affirms both terms of the numismatic problem at once. The lot is genuinely cast, an aleatory event, and its disposition is nonetheless providential. The Coen corpus retains the first clause and suspends the second. Its lots are cast on a filling-station counter, at a poker table where Buster Scruggs is dealt the dead man's hand, at the gaming tables where Arthur Gopnik puts his Mentaculus to work; but no disposer is shown, and the films decline to say whether there is one. The Coen cosmos is Proverbs 16:33 with its second clause in brackets.

Leviticus 16 deserves particular attention, since its lottery of the two goats furnishes the structure of an entire film. In *The Man Who Wasn't There*, Ed Crane kills Big Dave Brewster and his wife Doris is charged with the killing; Ed is later convicted and executed for the death of Creighton Tolliver, which Big Dave committed. Two goats stand before an altar of justice, and the lot falls on each for the other's deed. René Girard's account of the scapegoat (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972; *Le Bouc émissaire*, 1982), in which a community discharges its violence upon an arbitrarily designated victim, here meets its aleatory origin. The scapegoat of Leviticus is chosen not by the mob but by lot, and the Coens restore the lot to the mechanism Girard described.

2.2

The Hidden Face and the Purim-Shpil

In Deuteronomy God announces that, when Israel turns to other gods, 'I will surely hide my face in that day' (Deuteronomy 31:18). The rabbis heard in the doubled verb, *haster astir*, an allusion to the one biblical book in which God's name never appears: asked where Esther is indicated in the Torah, the Talmud answers with this verse (Chullin 139b). The pun identifies Esther with *hester panim*, the hiding of the face, and so marks the Book of Esther as the scripture of divine hiddenness. It is also, uniquely, the scripture of the lot. Its plot is set in motion by Haman's *pur*, reversed by a sequence of coincidences that no character arranges (a sleepless king, a chronicle read at random, a gallows built for one man and used for another), and commemorated in a festival named for chance.

Purim's rites are carnivalesque: masks, inversions of rank, parody, and the Talmudic dictum that one should drink until one cannot distinguish 'cursed be Haman' from 'blessed be Mordecai' (Megillah 7b), *ad de-lo yada*, 'until one does not know'. From the early modern period the festival generated the *Purim-shpil*, a Yiddish folk drama of burlesque, disguise,

and topsy-turvy justice. This dissertation proposes, and Chapter Nine develops, the thesis that Coen comedy is a Purim-shpil in a strict sense: a carnival performed in a world governed by lots, from which God's name is absent, in which villain and hero grow hard to tell apart, and whose epistemic telos is not knowledge but a disciplined not-knowing. Mikhail Bakhtin's account of carnival in *Rabelais and His World* (1965) supplies the general theory; Purim supplies the specific form. The fool is crowned: Norville Barnes ascends to the presidency of Hudsucker Industries because the board takes him for an idiot. Masks proliferate: con men, pseudonyms, a hired actor posing as an oil baron, an editor who does not exist. And the festivity of White Russians drunk in a bowling alley is never far from the gallows.

2.3

Rashi's Epigraph and the Prohibition of Divination

A Serious Man opens with an epigraph attributed to Rashi: 'Receive with simplicity everything that happens to you.' The source is Rashi's comment on Deuteronomy 18:13, 'Thou shalt be perfect \[*tamim*\] with the LORD thy God', and its context transforms its meaning. Deuteronomy 18:9–14 forbids divination, soothsaying, augury, sorcery, charming, the consulting of familiar spirits, and necromancy. Verse 13 concludes the prohibition, and Rashi glosses it as an instruction to walk with God in simplicity, to wait upon him, and not to probe the future, but to accept with simplicity whatever comes. The epigraph is therefore not a generic counsel of acceptance. It is a gloss on the prohibition of fortune-telling.

Read in context, the epigraph indicts in advance nearly every action of the film that follows. Larry Gopnik's pilgrimage to three rabbis is a consultation of oracles. The dentist Sussman's search for the meaning of the letters on his patient's teeth, conducted through gematria and the telephone directory, is divination. Arthur's Mentaculus is augury rendered as statistics. Even the film's editing, which juxtaposes Larry's acceptance of a bribe with a doctor's summons to discuss his X-rays, invites the spectator to divine a causal and moral connection that the film neither affirms nor denies. The epigraph's key word, moreover, is the epithet of Job, the man 'perfect and upright' (Job 1:1, *tam ve-yashar*), and it echoes the Thummim that was itself an instrument of lot-casting. Before a single image appears, Rashi has tied the film's protagonist to Job, to the lot, and to the prohibition of the very hermeneutic hunger that will consume him.

A Talmudic dictum sharpens the point. Rabbi Yochanan taught *ein mazal le-Yisrael*, that Israel is not subject to the constellations (Shabbat 156a): the people of the covenant are not governed by astral fate. *Mazal*, the planetary influence, survives in Yiddish as luck, and in Yiddish comic typology as the *shlimazl*, the one born under a bad constellation, whom Ruth Wisse's *The Schlemiel as Modern Hero* (1971) helps distinguish from his clumsier cousin, the *shlemiel*. Larry Gopnik is a *shlimazl* of almost liturgical purity. The film asks whether Rabbi Yochanan was right, whether Israel, and this Jew in a Minnesota suburb, is

exempt from *mazal*; and Arthur's Mentaculus, astrology recast as probability theory, is the film's comic proof that the forbidden question cannot be kept from being asked.

2.4

Job without the Speech

A Serious Man is the corpus's Book of Job, and it follows its model with a fidelity that has been underestimated because it is structural rather than allusive. Like Job, Larry suffers a cascade of losses without evident cause. His wife announces that she is leaving him for the unctuous Sy Ableman; his brother occupies the couch and drains a sebaceous cyst; anonymous letters reach his tenure committee; a student attempts to bribe him; a record club pursues him for an album he did not order; his neighbour encroaches on his lot line; his car is struck at the same moment that Sy dies in a collision across town. Like Job, Larry seeks counsel from three advisers, here three rabbis of diminishing accessibility. The junior rabbi, Scott, urges him to see God in the parking lot; Rabbi Nachtner tells the parable of the goy's teeth; Rabbi Marshak, the eldest, will not see him at all, and speaks only to the son, after his bar mitzvah. The homology with Job's three comforters, Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar, extends even to the figure of youth: where the Book of Job adds a fourth and youngest speaker, Elihu, after the three, the film assigns youth to the first rabbi rather than the last.

And like Job, Larry receives a whirlwind. In the final shots, as Larry, having at last altered the briber's grade, takes a call from his doctor asking him to come in about his X-rays, a tornado bears down on Danny's Hebrew school, and the children stand in the parking lot while their teacher fumbles for the key to the shelter. 'Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind' (Job 38:1). The Coens give the whirlwind and withhold the answer. The film ends where God's speech should begin. What in the Bible occasions the most sublime poetry in Hebrew scripture, a survey of creation from the foundations of the earth to Leviathan, is here a meteorological event filmed from a parking lot, followed by the credits. The withholding is the film's theology. The biblical speech never answers Job's question but at least asserts a presence. The tornado asserts nothing, and its arrival at the moment of Larry's transgression offers a providential reading that the cut to black neither confirms nor refutes.

Nachtner's parable is the film's hermeneutic centre. A Jewish dentist finds Hebrew letters engraved on the inner surface of a gentile patient's lower teeth, spelling *hoshi'eni*, 'help me' or 'save me', the opening cry of Psalm 69: 'Save me, O God; for the waters are come in unto my soul.' The dentist cannot sleep. He searches for a meaning, computes the letters' numerical values, and pursues them through the telephone directory, to no purpose; he consults the rabbi. Recounting all this to Larry, Nachtner declines to finish the story. Asked what became of the goy, he answers, in substance, that it does not matter, that we cannot know everything, and that helping others could not hurt. The sign is valid: it is written, it

addresses, it demands. It has no significance: nothing follows from it, no message is delivered, and the story of its discovery ends without issue. This is, to the letter, the condition Gershom Scholem named in his 1934 correspondence with Walter Benjamin on Kafka: the 'nothingness of revelation' (*Nichts der Offenbarung*), a state in which revelation still asserts itself, inasmuch as it is valid, but has no significance (*Geltung ohne Bedeutung*). Scholem's phrase, which he glosses in a letter printed on page 142 of the English edition of their correspondence, is the most exact description of the Coen sign available in the critical literature, and it was written half a century before the first Coen film.

Two details complete the film's theology. The first is its prologue, a Yiddish folktale in which a shtetl wife stabs a visitor she believes to be a dybbuk, the possessing spirit of a man three years dead, and the visitor walks out bleeding into the snow, neither confirmed dead nor confirmed alive. The prologue's undecidability prefigures the Schrödinger's cat that Larry will teach, and its victim's name, Groshkover, carries in the Yiddish *groshn* the echo of a small coin. The second detail is the record club. Throughout the film, the Columbia Record Club pursues Larry by telephone for payment for Santana's *Abraxas*, an album released in 1970 and thus anachronistic in a film set in 1967. Abraxas is the Gnostic deity of the Basilidean system, the god who in C. G. Jung's 'Seven Sermons to the Dead' (1916) and Hermann Hesse's *Demian* (1919) unites good and evil in a single divinity beyond the moral God. In *A Serious Man* this god appears only as an unpaid debt, demanded by a distant collections department, arriving before its time. No single prop in the corpus states numismatic theology more economically: the god beyond good and evil, encountered as a bill. The mechanics of the debt sharpen the theology. The subscription was taken out by Danny in his father's name, and the club works by negative option: the month's selection is shipped and billed unless the member declines it, so that by doing nothing Larry keeps ordering a record he does not want. The son incurs the debt, the father is billed for it, and passivity itself is charged as consent. Rashi's counsel to receive with simplicity everything that happens has been converted into a billing practice: at the Columbia Record Club, to receive is to buy.

2.5

Maimonides, Kafka, and the Door

Maimonides read the Book of Job as a philosophical parable (*Guide of the Perplexed* III.22–23). Job, he argued, possessed moral virtue but not true knowledge of God; his complaint arose from the assumption that divine providence resembles human governance; and his torment ceased when he understood that God's knowledge, purpose, and providence share only the name with ours. Elsewhere Maimonides holds that individual providence extends to human beings in proportion to their intellectual perfection (*Guide* III.17–18). *A Serious Man* reads like a comic test of both theses. Its Job is a physicist, whose intellectual attain-

ments should place him high on the Maimonidean scale of providence, and whose suffering is undiminished. And the knowledge that might console him, that God's ways are equivocal with ours, is precisely what the film's rabbis, physics, and parables keep offering in degraded forms ('Accept the mystery', says the father of the student who bribed him) without ever making it his.

The treatment of Rabbi Marshak reproduces Kafka's parable 'Before the Law' (1915), in which a man from the country waits his whole life before a door watched by a doorkeeper and learns at the moment of death that the door was meant for him alone. Larry is turned away by Marshak's secretary, who tells him the rabbi is busy; he does not look busy, Larry protests; he is thinking, she replies. Marshak does speak at last, but to Danny, after the bar mitzvah, and what he offers is a solemn recitation of the opening of Jefferson Airplane's 'Somebody to Love', together with the names of the band's members, and the return of a confiscated transistor radio in whose case Danny has hidden the twenty dollars he owes a schoolyard dealer. The oracle speaks in the idiom of the radio; the sacred text is a pop song of disenchantment; the gift returned to the boy contains a debt. Validity without significance could not be staged more literally. The Law speaks, with all the authority of age and office, and what it utters is the radio.

2.6

Contraction, Kenosis, and the Schlemiel

The Kabbalah of Isaac Luria, as Scholem reconstructed it in *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941), begins with *tzimtzum*, God's contraction into himself to make room for a world; continues with *shevirat ha-kelim*, the breaking of the vessels that could not contain the divine light; and assigns to human beings the work of *tikkun*, the repair of the world through the gathering of sparks scattered among the husks (*kelipot*) of matter. Christian theology knows an analogue in *kenosis*, the self-emptying by which the divine 'made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant' (Philippians 2:7). After the Second World War, Hans Jonas proposed in 'The Concept of God after Auschwitz' (1984) a God who had renounced omnipotence in creating a world capable of such events, and Emmanuel Levinas argued in 'Useless Suffering' (1982) that justifying the neighbour's pain is the source of all immorality, so that after the twentieth century theodicy had itself become obscene.

The Coen world is post-Lurianic: a cosmos after contraction, in which the vessels of meaning, genres, institutions, and rituals, have broken, and the sparks lie scattered among the husks of American commerce: bowling alleys, car lots, barbershops, dry cleaners, motels, furniture showrooms, gyms, record clubs. Whether anyone gathers them is the question of the edge. The post-Lurianic frame also accounts for the corpus's quiet but insistent engagement with the Holocaust, the murder of some six million European Jews by Nazi Germany

and its collaborators. *Barton Fink* is set in 1941, the year in which German mobile killing units began the mass shooting of Jews across the occupied Soviet territories; its Jewish playwright is patronised by a Jewish mogul and menaced by a 'common man' who turns out to be Karl Mundt, a killer who cries 'Heil Hitler' as he shoots a detective named Deutsch. *Miller's Crossing* turns on Bernie Bernbaum, the Jewish bookie whom his Italian enemy calls 'the Shmatte', Yiddish for a rag and here an antisemitic slur, and whom an Irish fixer spares in the woods and later kills. These are not allegories. They are residues of a cosmos in which theodicy has become impossible and comedy obligatory.

Hannah Arendt, reporting on the trial of Adolf Eichmann, the SS officer who organised the deportation of Europe's Jews to the killing centres, described his evil as banal: a matter of thoughtlessness and careerism rather than demonic depth (*Eichmann in Jerusalem*, 1963). Her last book was titled *The Life of the Mind* (1978). *Barton Fink* anticipates both phrases and inverts both. Its hero claims the life of the mind and fails to think about the man in the next room; the common man he romanticises turns out to be a murderer who salutes Hitler, and whose evil is neither banal nor thoughtless but theatrical, a performance staged in fire. The resonance with Arendt is not a source. It is a measure of how exactly the film locates the intellectual's failure of attention in 1941, the year the mass shootings of the Holocaust began.

The film's plotting supports the reading more closely than its imagery alone. The detectives who hunt Mundt bear an Italian and a German name, Mastrionotti and Deutsch, and Mundt executes Deutsch with a Nazi salute. Before he vanishes into the burning hotel he tells Barton that he has paid a visit to the playwright's parents and uncle in New York, and when Barton telephones, no one answers. The film never shows what happened in that apartment, and in 1941 it does not need to. The killer's name, moreover, is shared with Karl E. Mundt, the anti-communist congressman who sat on the House Un-American Activities Committee in the years of its Hollywood hearings, so that the common man the Popular Front playwright romanticises wears the name of the inquisition that would break the Popular Front in Hollywood.

The figure who inhabits such a cosmos is the schlemiel, whom Wisse presents as the exemplary hero of modern Jewish fiction: the fool whose defeats expose the inadequacy of the world's standards of victory. Isaac Bashevis Singer's Gimpel the Fool (1953), who believes every lie he is told and concludes that the world is entirely imaginary but only once removed from the true one, is the schlemiel as saint. He is Larry Gopnik's precise inverse, for Gimpel receives everything with simplicity, as Rashi commanded, while Larry receives nothing without asking why. Sholem Aleichem's Tevye, who argues with God in a patchwork of misquoted scripture, is the schlemiel as comic Job. Bernard Malamud's *The Fixer* (1966), whose hero suffers a Job-like imprisonment for a ritual murder he did not commit, lends its title to a figure Chapter Four will find throughout the corpus. And Walter Sobchak, the

convert who keeps a Sabbath no one asks of him, belongs to this company as the schlemiel-zealot. The schlemiel is the human being proportioned to a world of lots. Chapter Three asks what the lot itself is.



Αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων·
παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη. *Lifetime is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child.*
— Heraclitus, fragment B52

CHAPTER THREE

A Natural History of the Toss

Chance from Heraclitus to Meillassoux

3.1

The Child-King

The oldest surviving statement of the Coen cosmos is a fragment of Heraclitus: lifetime (*aion*) is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child (B52). The fragment joins the two terms that numismatic theology finds fused in the coin, sovereignty and chance, and assigns both to a child. Nietzsche, who praised Heraclitus as the thinker of the innocence of becoming, and Gilles Deleuze, who read the fragment through Nietzsche's throw of the dice (*Nietzsche et la philosophie*, 1962), took it as an affirmation of chance purged of guilt. The Coens take it literally. In *The Hudsucker Proxy* (1994), a conglomerate's fortunes are restored by a child's toy, the hula hoop, whose inventor, a naïf from Muncie, carries a drawing of a circle and explains it only with the phrase 'You know, for kids!'. In *Raising Arizona* (1987), the kingdom of Unpainted Arizona, a furniture empire,

is figured in its heir, one of five quintuplets, whom everyone in the film desires to possess. *Fargo* ends with a countdown to a birth, 'two more months'; *The Big Lebowski* closes with its narrator's report of a 'little Lebowski on the way'. The child-king presides over the Coen cosmos. The kingship belongs, as Heraclitus said, to a child at play.

3.2

Tyche and Automaton

Aristotle's treatment of chance (*Physics* II.4–6) distinguishes *tyche*, luck in the sphere of human purpose, from *automaton*, spontaneity in nature, and defines both as accidental causes: events that happen as if for an end, without one. His paradigm case is economic. A man goes to the marketplace for some other purpose and happens on his debtor at the moment the debtor is collecting money, and so recovers what he is owed (II.5); had he known, he would have gone for that purpose. At its origin in Western philosophy, chance is a coincidence of encounter and debt. Jacques Lacan's eleventh seminar (1964) repurposed Aristotle's pair. *Automaton* names the insistence of the signifying chain, the network of signs that returns and repeats; *tuché* names the encounter with the real that the chain cannot assimilate. The Coen plot is an *automaton*, a genre machine whose signifiers return with the regularity of a clock, punctured at decisive moments by *tuché*: a wood chipper in a Minnesota yard, a tornado over a suburban school, a car that runs a light and broadsides Anton Chigurh.

3.3

The Swerve

Lucretius (*De rerum natura* II.216–293), following Epicurus, held that atoms falling through the void would never collide unless, at uncertain times and places, they swerved a little, and that this swerve, the *clinamen*, is at once the origin of worlds and the ground of the will's freedom. Louis Althusser's late writings on aleatory materialism (1982) made the swerve and the 'encounter that takes hold' the underground current of Western philosophy from Epicurus to Machiavelli and Marx. Harold Bloom made *clinamen* the first of the revisionary ratios by which strong poets swerve from their precursors (*The Anxiety of Influence*, 1973). Both senses apply. The Coens' relation to their genres is a clinamen in Bloom's sense, a swerve that keeps the precursor's trajectory recognisable while deflecting it. And their plots begin with swerves in Lucretius's: Llewelyn Moss's hunting detour, which leads him to a circle of dead men and a satchel of money; the collision that kills Sy Ableman as Larry crashes across town; the crash in *The Man Who Wasn't There* when Birdy Abundas makes a sexual advance on Ed Crane as he drives and he refuses it; the cat that Llewyn Davis strikes on a dark road.

3.4

Fortune's Wheel

Boethius composed *The Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524) in prison awaiting execution. In its second book Fortune speaks in her own defence: she has merely taken back what was always hers, and mutability is her nature. In its fifth, Philosophy reconciles providence and freedom by distinguishing God's eternity, the whole, simultaneous, and perfect possession of interminable life, a standing now (Boethius's *nunc permanens*, the scholastics' *nunc stans*), from the temporal succession in which creatures act. Two Coen films restage the *Consolation*. *The Man Who Wasn't There* is narrated by a condemned man awaiting the electric chair, who discloses near its end that he is setting down his story for a men's magazine that pays by the word: the consolation of philosophy, monetised per word. The rate is five cents a word, and the voice-over we have heard throughout the film is that piece of copy: the narration is the commodity, and when Ed says that writing it has helped him 'sort it all out', the magazine's nickel has bought the consolation. *The Hudsucker Proxy* is the corpus's Boethian machine. Its world is a mechanism of circles, the market's wheel, the hoop, the giant clock that crowns the Hudsucker building. At its climax, as Norville Barnes falls from the top of the building on New Year's Eve, the old clock-keeper Moses jams the clock's works, time stops, and the dead founder descends with wings to explain the providential letter in Norville's pocket. Moses produces the *nunc stans*: an instant in which the fall is suspended and all times are present together.

Machiavelli's *Prince* (1532), chapter 25, gives Fortune two images: a violent river that floods the plains, against which prudent men build dikes and embankments in calm weather, and a woman who yields to those who master her. The Coens take the first at its word. *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* ends with a flood that drowns a valley at the moment its heroes are about to be hanged. Machiavelli's river arrives, and no *virtù* tames it; it is released by the Tennessee Valley Authority. Tom Reagan in *Miller's Crossing* is the corpus's Machiavellian counsellor, a man of supreme *virtù* who manipulates every faction in a city of gangs, yet whose personal relation to fortune is that of a losing gambler perpetually in debt to his bookmaker. His *virtù* governs others' fortunes far more surely than it governs his own.

3.5

The Wager

Pascal's wager (*Pensées*, Lafuma 418) is the most famous toss in philosophy, and Pascal frames it as one. Reason cannot decide whether God exists; a game is being played at the far end of an infinite distance, where heads or tails (*croix ou pile*) will turn up; one must wager, for the wager is not optional: *vous êtes embarqué*, you are already embarked. The fragment's companion is Pascal's confession that the eternal silence of these infinite spaces

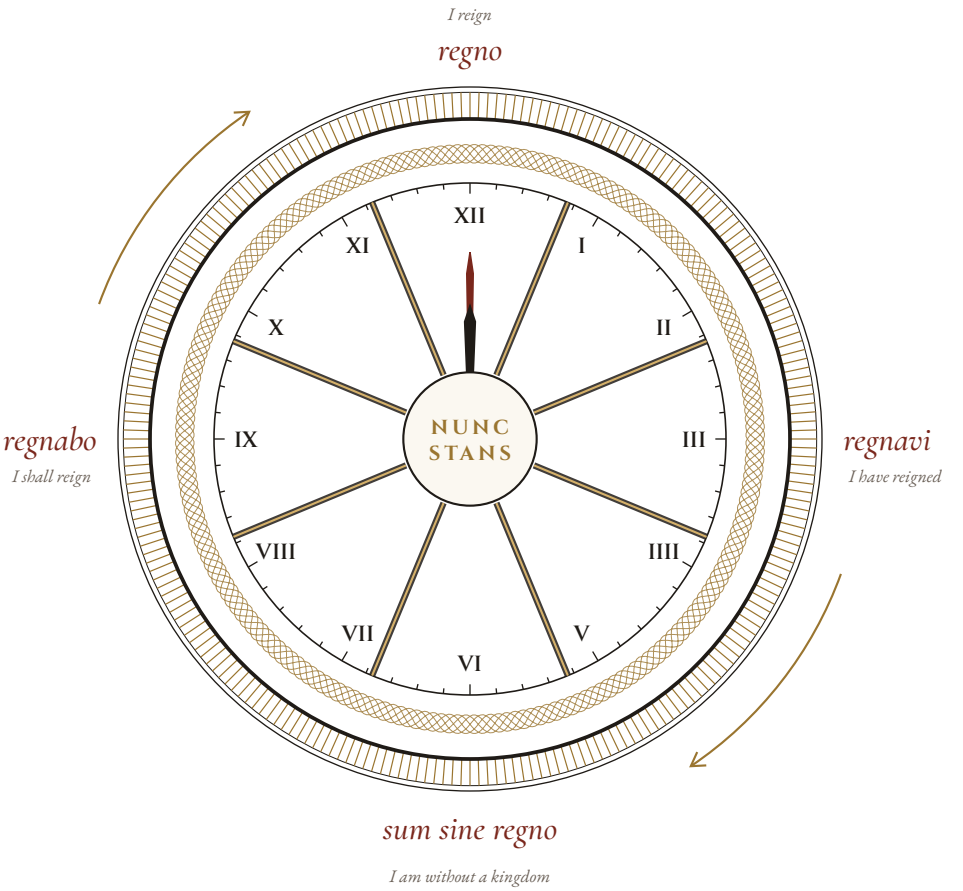


FIG. 5 Fortune's wheel and the Hudsucker clock. The four stations of the medieval wheel (*regnabo*, *regno*, *regnavi*, *sum sine regno*) ring a clock stopped at midnight: Moses jams the works, the fall is suspended, and all times stand present together.

terrifies him (Lafuma 201). Chigurh's 'call it' is the wager inverted point for point. Pascal's wagerer chooses, and the stakes are infinite; Chigurh's victim calls, but the coin chooses, and the stake is a finite life. Pascal's game is played at an infinite distance, Chigurh's on a counter. Pascal argues that the embarked should wager on God; Chigurh informs the proprietor that he has been embarked all his life without knowing it. The Coen universe is the silence of the infinite spaces with Pascal's argument removed and his metaphor retained. From this angle, Carla Jean's refusal is the corpus's only principled rejection of the wager: she declines to be embarked. Llewelyn Moss, by contrast, is its purest Pascalian, a man who stakes everything on a satchel whose bottom he cannot see.

3.6

The Demon, the Butterfly, and the Taming of Chance

In the *Essai philosophique sur les probabilités* (1814), Laplace imagined an intelligence that, knowing at one instant all the forces of nature and the positions of all its bodies, would embrace in a single formula the motions of the greatest bodies and the lightest atoms; for it nothing would be uncertain, and the future, like the past, would be present to its eyes. Laplace's demon is the secular heir of Boethius's God, and Arthur Gopnik's Mentaculus is the demon in a spiral notebook: a probability map of the universe composed by an unemployed man with a cyst, which works, after a fashion, at the gaming table. Henri Poincaré observed in *Science et méthode* (1908) that very small causes which escape our notice can determine considerable effects, so that prediction becomes impossible. Edward Lorenz gave the observation its emblem in 1972, in a talk titled 'Predictability: Does the Flap of a Butterfly's Wings in Brazil Set Off a Tornado in Texas?'. The emblem of sensitive dependence on initial conditions is a tornado, and *A Serious Man* ends with one. *Fargo* and *Burn After Reading* are Lorenzian plots in which a trivial scheme, a car salesman's ransom plan, two gym employees' discovery of a disc, cascades into multiple deaths.

Ian Hacking's histories of probability (*The Emergence of Probability*, 1975; *The Taming of Chance*, 1990) describe the nineteenth-century 'avalanche of printed numbers' through which statistical regularities came to be read as laws, and chance, once the mark of ignorance, was tamed into a governable quantity. The Coen corpus inhabits the institutions of tamed chance. It inhabits insurance, in the lineage of James M. Cain's *Double Indemnity*, which *The Man Who Wasn't There* acknowledges by naming Big Dave's wife Ann Nirdlinger after the murdered husband of Cain's novel. It inhabits consumer finance, in Jerry Lundegaard's fraud against the General Motors Acceptance Corporation, sustained by illegible vehicle identification numbers. It inhabits the tenure file, the record club, and the bookmaker's ledger. In each, chance is administered by numbers, and in each the numbers are falsified.

3.7

Tychism, Anancism, Agapism

The American philosopher who took chance most seriously is the one whose triad will organise this dissertation. In 'The Doctrine of Necessity Examined' (1892), Charles Sanders Peirce argued against the mechanical philosophy that absolute chance is a real feature of the universe, a doctrine he named tychism. In 'Evolutionary Love' (1893) he proposed that the cosmos evolves in three modes: tychastic evolution, by fortuitous variation; anancastic evolution, by mechanical necessity; and agapastic evolution, by creative love, in which growth is drawn by sympathy toward the ends of others. Peirce took the agapastic mode from the Gospel of John and set it explicitly against what he called the gospel of greed, the political

economy of his century, which he regarded as an apologia for selfishness dressed as natural law. A century before the Coens, Peirce supplies an American cosmology in which chance, necessity, and love are the three operations of the world, and in which love is defined against money. Chapter Nine maps the triad onto the coin: the reverse is tychastic, the obverse anancastic, the edge agapastic.

3.8

Dice, Uncertainty, and Synchronicity

In December 1926 Einstein wrote to Max Born that he was convinced that 'He' does not play at dice; the next year Heisenberg published the uncertainty relations, and in 1935 Schrödinger devised his cat to expose the absurdity of extending superposition to macroscopic objects. The Coens dramatise the uncertainty principle twice, eight years apart, in registers that together cover the numismatic domain. In *The Man Who Wasn't There* (2001), the defence lawyer Freddy Riedenschneider explains to Ed Crane that a German scientist has shown that looking at a thing changes it, so that one cannot know what really happened, and proposes to build Doris's defence on reasonable doubt elevated into ontological principle. In *A Serious Man* (2009), Larry teaches the uncertainty principle and the dead cat, insists that the mathematics is how it works, and dreams of a lecture in which the principle proves that we can never really know what is going on. The legal and the cosmological uncertainty are one uncertainty: in both, observation is entangled with verdict.

Larry's car crash, timed to coincide with Sy Ableman's fatal one, invokes the hypothesis that the physicist Wolfgang Pauli and C. G. Jung advanced in *Naturerklärung und Psyche* (1952): synchronicity, an acausal connecting principle by which events are linked by meaning rather than cause. The film supplies the meaningful coincidence and withholds the meaning. Nietzsche's Zarathustra calls the sky a dance floor for divine accidents and a table for divine dice ('Before Sunrise'); his eternal recurrence (*The Gay Science* §341) the Coens literalise in the closed week of *Inside Llewyn Davis*. And Mallarmé's *Un coup de dés jamais n'abolira le hasard* (1897) states the one proposition the corpus never contradicts: a throw of the dice will never abolish chance.

3.9

Hyper-Chaos and the Spectral Dilemma

Quentin Meillassoux's *Après la finitude* (2006) radicalises contingency into a principle: the only necessity is the necessity of contingency, and nothing, the laws of nature included, has a reason to remain as it is. Meillassoux calls the resulting time hyper-chaos, a time capable of destroying every law without reason. His essay 'Spectral Dilemma' (2008) turns the principle on the problem of atrocious deaths. Before the specters of those who died terribly and

unmourned, we face a dilemma: if God exists, he permitted these deaths and is unworthy of worship; if he does not, the deaths are irreparable and we despair. Meillassoux's resolution is that God does not yet exist: a God of justice capable of raising the dead is not necessary but possible, since hyper-chaos forbids nothing. The Coen corpus is crowded with specters in Meillassoux's sense: the state trooper and the two passing motorists shot by Gaear Grimsrud on a Minnesota highway, Jean Lundegaard, killed by the same man while held for a ransom her husband designed, the deputy strangled in a Texas jail and the motorist killed for his car, both by Anton Chigurh, Alice Longabaugh, dead by her own hand on the wagon train in the mistaken belief that the battle was lost, the limbless orator whom, the film implies, his impresario throws from a bridge. The films neither mourn nor justify these dead. They leave them as specters, unconsoled by theodicy and unconsoled by atheism.

In *Métaphysique et fiction des mondes hors-science* (2013), translated as *Science Fiction and Extro-Science Fiction*, Meillassoux distinguishes science fiction, which imagines worlds whose laws differ from ours but remain knowable, from extro-science fiction, which imagines worlds in which regularities break down so that science becomes impossible. The Coens, this dissertation proposes, practise extro-science fiction in realist dress. Their worlds are scrupulously period-exact and physically ordinary, yet in them a flying saucer drifts over a prison yard, a dead man returns with wings, a tornado arrives on cue, and a dream summons a biker of the apocalypse who then appears. The breaks are rare and unexplained, and their rarity is the point. They are not a second set of laws but evidence that the first set is contingent.

3.10

The Physics of the Coin

The natural history of the toss ends in physics, and the physics yields the dissertation's least expected datum. Persi Diaconis, Susan Holmes, and Richard Montgomery showed in 'Dynamical Bias in the Coin Toss' (*SIAM Review*, 2007) that a flipped coin is a deterministic mechanical system whose outcome depends on its initial conditions, and that natural flips carry a slight bias, of the order of fifty-one per cent, toward the face that was up at the start. A large empirical study of more than 350,000 tosses (Bartoš et al., 2023) has since reported the same bias. The coin, in other words, remembers. Chigurh's coin, which he says has travelled twenty-two years to reach the counter, is not an emblem of pure chance but of forgotten determinism: a causal history too long and too fine to follow, which presents itself to finite observers as chance. The corpus oscillates between this classical, epistemic chance and the quantum, ontological chance of Riedenschneider's and Larry's uncertainty. *No Country* belongs to Laplace; *A Serious Man* belongs to Heisenberg.

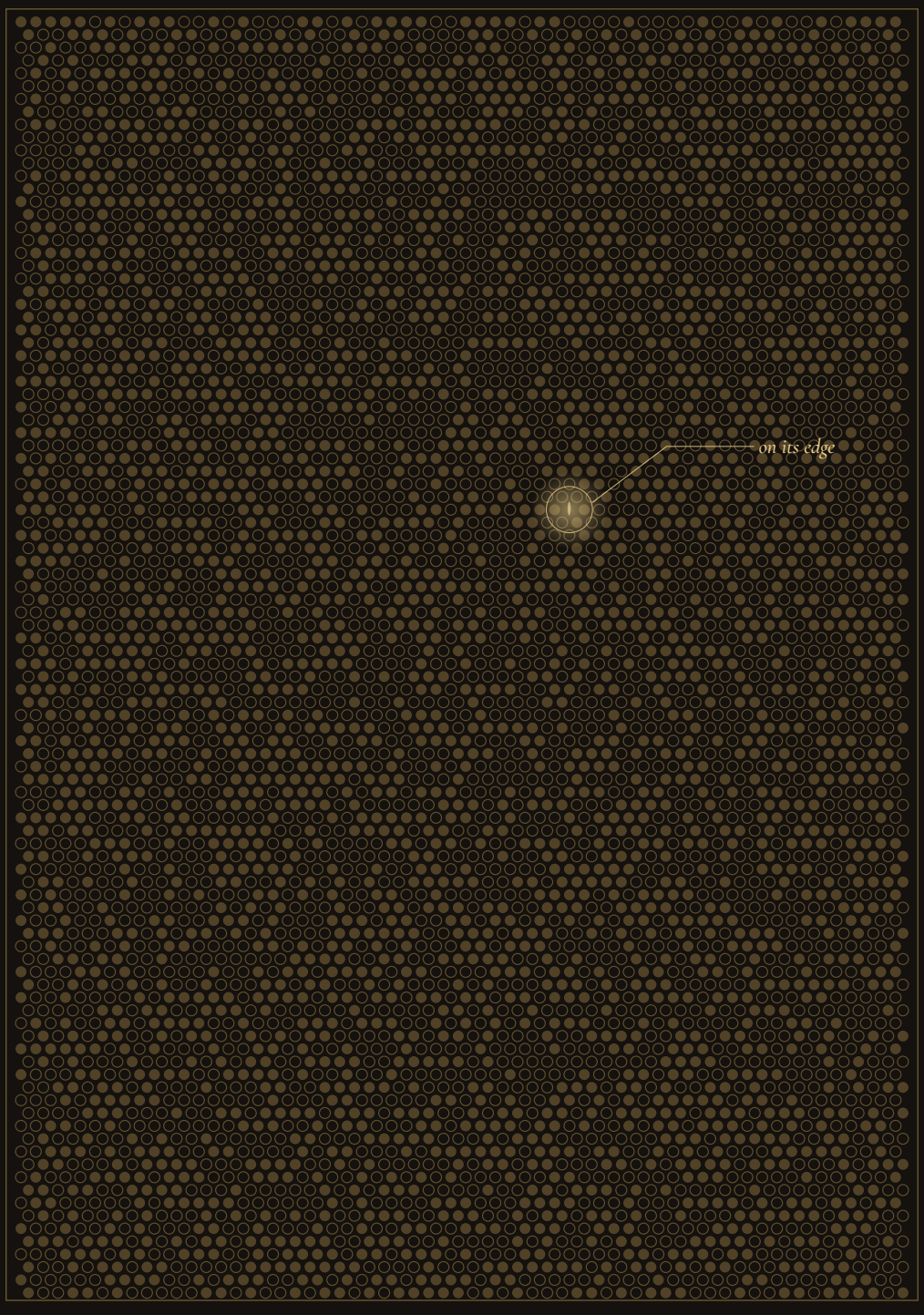
And a coin does not have two possible outcomes, but three. Daniel Murray and Scott Teare, modelling the problem in *Physical Review E* (1993), estimated that an American



FIG. 6 The coin remembers. A natural flip is a deterministic motion with a slight bias, of the order of fifty-one per cent, toward the face that started up (Diaconis, Holmes and Montgomery 2007; Bartoš et al. 2023), here drawn as a chronophotograph of one toss in fifteen exposures.

nickel tossed onto a hard surface comes to rest on its edge roughly once in six thousand throws. The edge is improbable, unstable, and real. It is the outcome in which the coin declines to decide. The rest of this dissertation may be summarised as the claim that the Coen corpus locates grace at a frequency of approximately one in six thousand.

The figure deserves its exact status. Murray and Teare did not toss six thousand nickels. They built a dynamical model of the toss, measured how the probability of landing in the less stable position varies with an object's proportions, and extrapolated to the nickel, noting that the result had not been tested experimentally; the probability falls steeply as a coin grows thinner relative to its width, so that a quarter, flatter than a nickel, is less likely still to stand. One in six thousand is therefore an inference, not an observation: a frequency computed for an event the experiment did not witness. The edge has, in this precise sense, the epistemic status the Coen corpus gives to grace. It is calculable, real, and rare, and it is known chiefly by reasoning from the cases one can see.



ONE IN SIX THOUSAND

Six thousand tosses of an American nickel onto a hard surface, and one comes to rest on its edge. Murray and Teare's figure (1993) is an inference from a model, not an observation: calculable, real and rare, the epistemic status the corpus gives to grace.



PART TWO

The Three Faces

CHAPTER FOUR
The Obverse

CHAPTER FIVE
The Reverse

CHAPTER SIX
The Edge, I

CHAPTER SEVEN
The Edge, II



And he saith unto them, Whose is this image and superscription? They say unto him, Caesar's. Then saith he unto them, Render therefore unto Caesar the things which are Caesar's; and unto God the things that are God's.

— Matthew 22:20–21

CHAPTER FOUR

The Obverse

Sovereignty, the Fix, and Political Theology

4.1

The Two Senses of the Fix

The obverse of a coin bears the sovereign's image, and the sovereign's characteristic act in the Coen corpus is the fix. The English verb carries two senses that the corpus holds in permanent tension. To fix is to repair, the secular cousin of the Hebrew *tikkun*; to fix is also to rig, to predetermine an outcome that should have been left to chance, as one fixes a fight, a race, or an election. The first sense restores a broken order; the second abolishes contingency. The corpus is crowded with fixers in both senses: Johnny Caspar, who fixes fights; Tom Reagan, who fixes a city; Eddie Mannix, whose whole work at Capitol Pictures is fixing; Jerry Lundegaard, who fixes paperwork; Sidney J. Mussburger, who fixes a stock price; Jack Lipnick, who fixes a writer's contract; the Big Lebowski, who exploits a kidnapping to cover an embezzlement. Carl Schmitt opened *Political Theology* (1922) with the

proposition that sovereign is he who decides on the exception, and argued that all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularised theological concepts. The Coen fixer is the sovereign of a secularised world: the one who decides on the exception to chance. Every fix in the corpus fails, and the manner of its failure is the subject of this chapter.

4.2

Miller's Crossing: The Ethics of the Fix

Miller's Crossing (1990) opens with a speech about ethics. Johnny Caspar, an Italian boss in an unnamed Prohibition-era city, complains to Leo O'Bannon, the Irish boss who owns the mayor and the police, that the bookie Bernie Bernbaum has been selling word of Caspar's fixed fights, so that the odds shift and the fixes are spoiled. Caspar's 'ethics' is the principle that a fixed outcome should stay fixed. It is a demand for the abolition of chance within his domain, and Bernie, who leaks information that restores uncertainty, is its enemy. In Schmittian terms Caspar seeks a sovereign guarantee against the exception; in Hobbesian terms he seeks a covenant that will lift the city out of the condition of war of every man against every man (*Leviathan*, 1651, chapter 13) by making outcomes predictable. The 'friendship' and 'character' he invokes are names for the stability of fixes.

Tom Reagan, Leo's counsellor, is the corpus's most enigmatic agent of sovereignty. Ordered to kill Bernie at Miller's Crossing, the wooded place of exception outside the city where bodies are left, he hears Bernie, on his knees, beg him to look into his heart, fires into the ground, and lets him go. The act is clemency, the sovereign prerogative Seneca commended to Nero in *De clementia*, and it is the one unforced decision in the film. It is also catastrophic. Bernie kills Mink, the lover of Caspar's enforcer, the Dane, shooting him in the face and leaving him at Miller's Crossing as a decoy for his own body; when the Dane brings Tom to the woods to confirm the killing, birds have made the face unrecognisable, and the corpse passes for Bernie's own: a counterfeit corpse, a face effaced so that one body can circulate as another, the effigy filed from the coin. The counterfeit circulates twice: to the Dane it is Bernie's body, and to Caspar, once Tom has worked on him, Mink's disappearance becomes evidence of the Dane's betrayal, so that a faceless corpse buys Tom his enemy's death. Bernie then returns to blackmail Tom, and when, near the end, Bernie again appeals to his heart, Tom asks 'What heart?' and kills him. Mercy, the sovereign exception to the law of the fix, has proved the most dangerous variable of all, because it reintroduces into a fixed world the chance the world was organised to exclude.

Tom tells Verna a dream in which his hat blew off in the woods. He did not chase it, he insists; there is nothing more foolish than a man chasing his hat. The hat is the film's beetle-box, a sign of status and self whose loss Tom declines to pursue. But the woods in which it blows away are also the sacred grove of an older order. Frazer opens *The Golden Bough* (1890) with the King of the Wood at Nemi, the priest who guards a sacred tree until he is slain by

his successor. *Miller's Crossing* is a story of succession in the grove. Tom engineers Leo's fall and restoration, Caspar's death, and the elimination of every rival, and in the final scene, at Bernie's burial, he refuses Leo's offer to return to his side. He has killed the king's enemies and declined the crown, and the film ends on his face beneath a hat brim, unreadable. The sovereign decision in the Coen corpus is never to rule. It is, at most, to refuse rule.

4.3

The Hudsucker Proxy: The Child-King and the Restrainer

The Hudsucker Proxy is a fable of the fix. When the founder of Hudsucker Industries leaps from the boardroom window in mid-meeting, the board, led by Sidney J. Mussburger, plots to depress the company's stock by installing an idiot as president, so that its members can buy the founder's controlling shares cheaply before they pass to the public. The idiot, Norville Barnes, invents the hula hoop. The child's toy, a circle without content, becomes a national craze and makes the company's fortune; the fix fails because the sovereign board cannot anticipate a child's game. Heraclitus's fragment is enacted almost diagrammatically: the kingship belongs to a child at play. The film's sources, Frank Capra's populist fables and the Horatio Alger myth of rising from rags to riches, are refracted through Nathanael West's savage parody of Alger, *A Cool Million* (1934), whose hero is progressively dismembered by his pursuit of success. Norville rises, falls, and very nearly dies in the fall.

He is saved by a figure that Schmitt's later political theology names the *katechon*, after Paul's 'he who now letteth' (2 Thessalonians 2:7), the restrainer who holds back the end. As Norville plunges from the top of the building at midnight on New Year's Eve, Moses, the clock-keeper who has narrated the film and is its only wise man, jams the great clock, and time stops. Moses is the corpus's most literal katechon: the man who restrains catastrophe by stopping the clock. In the suspended instant, the dead founder descends with wings to tell Norville that the blue envelope in his pocket, a letter he was entrusted to deliver and never did, bequeaths the founder's shares to his successor in the presidency. It is the only letter in the Coen corpus that reaches its addressee, and it needs an angel and the stopping of time to arrive. The exception confirms the rule Chapter Five develops: in the Coen world, letters arrive only by miracle.

4.4

Barton Fink: The Studio as Sovereign

Capitol Pictures, the fictional studio of *Barton Fink* (set in 1941) and, a quarter-century later in the brothers' career, of *Hail, Caesar!* (set in 1951), is the corpus's sovereign institution. In *Barton Fink*, its head, Jack Lipnick, a composite of the great studio moguls, assures the playwright that the writer is king at Capitol Pictures and, to prove it, drops to his knees and

kisses Barton's shoes. The gesture belongs to the ritual repertoire that Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) teaches us to read: the sovereign's abasement, like the ruler's washing of feet, displays the dignity of the office by humbling the person. It is also a lie. Barton's contract binds him to write what Lipnick wants, and when he submits a script about the life of the mind instead of a wrestling picture, Lipnick, now in uniform after Pearl Harbor, condemns him to remain under contract without anything he writes ever being produced. The sovereign's kiss was the fix. The writer is king as Norville is president: a proxy installed so that the real power may operate unobserved.

The shoes deserve attention. The Hotel Earle's corridors are lined with the paired shoes of guests who are never seen, and the mogul's homage is paid to a writer's shoes. Martin Heidegger's 'Der Ursprung des Kunstwerkes' (1935–36) read a painting of shoes by Van Gogh as disclosing the world of the peasant woman who wore them; Meyer Schapiro objected (1968) that the shoes were the painter's own; Jacques Derrida's 'Restitutions', in *La Vérité en peinture* (1978), asked what it would mean to return shoes to an owner at all. *Barton Fink* stages that question in a hotel corridor. The shoes outside every door stand for persons who never appear, and the writer whose shoes the sovereign kisses does not, by contract, own what he writes.

4.5

Hail, Caesar!: The Grand Inquisitor in Culver City

Hail, Caesar! is the corpus's most elaborate political theology, and its key is Dostoevsky. In the Grand Inquisitor chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan imagines Christ returning to sixteenth-century Seville, where the aged Inquisitor arrests him and explains that the Church has corrected his work: humanity cannot bear the freedom Christ offered and craves instead miracle, mystery, and authority, which the Church supplies out of compassion for human weakness. Eddie Mannix is the Grand Inquisitor of Capitol Pictures. His studio supplies miracle, in the spectacles of a swimming star rising from a pool, a chorus of dancing sailors, a Roman epic; mystery, in the manufactured private lives of its stars; and authority, in Mannix's own management of every scandal. Like the Inquisitor, Mannix is personally austere and anguished. He goes to confession almost daily, his sins comically venial, chiefly the cigarettes he has promised his wife to give up, and throughout the film he is tempted by an executive from Lockheed who offers him an easier and better-paid life and shows him a photograph of a hydrogen bomb test at Bikini Atoll, adding that Lockheed was there. Mannix, studying it, says one word: Armageddon. The tempter, who offers Mannix a cigarette at each of their meetings, presses on him the very sin Mannix confesses daily, and the scene, set in a dim restaurant rather than a wilderness, is the temptation of Christ (Matthew 4:1–11) relocated to the defence industry. The photograph is also impossible: no

hydrogen bomb had been tested by 1951, and the first, in November 1952, was detonated at Enewetak, not Bikini. The apocalypse reaches the film before it had happened.

The film's theological symposium, at which a rabbi, a priest, a minister, and a patriarch debate the nature of God in order to vet the Christ picture, functions as the *Symposium* of a disenchanted Athens. Each speaker defines God from his tradition, the rabbi objecting to the very premise that God has a son, and the debate dissolves into a quarrel no one wins while Mannix takes note of whether the picture will offend. Meanwhile its star, Baird Whitlock, is kidnapped by 'The Future', a cell of Communist screenwriters whose study group includes the philosopher Herbert Marcuse, and who explain to him, in a Malibu beach house, the theory of surplus value and the studio's exploitation of their labour. The film thus places inside its fiction the Frankfurt School critique of the culture industry (Horkheimer and Adorno, *Dialektik der Aufklärung*, 1944/1947) and of one-dimensional man (Marcuse, 1964). It neither refutes nor endorses that critique. It does something stranger: it stages the culture industry as a church and its fixer as a saint.

Kantorowicz's doctrine of the king's two bodies, the mortal body natural and the undying body politic, explains the star. While Baird's body natural is held in Malibu, his body politic, the image on the screen, continues to circulate, and the studio's anxiety is that the two be reunited before the image is damaged. Baird's climactic speech as a Roman tribune converted at the foot of the cross, delivered flawlessly, culminates in a word he cannot remember: faith. The speech has every attribute of revelation, its form, its authority, its crescendo, except the word for which the crescendo was built. Scholem's validity without significance becomes a line reading. Earlier, slapping Baird back into service after his return from Malibu, Mannix had couched his sermon in the coin's own vocabulary: the picture has worth, and Baird has worth only if he serves the picture. In Capitol's theology, value is conferred by service to the image.

At the film's end Mannix declines Lockheed. He chooses the studio's dream over the bomb's reality, and in the vocabulary of Schmitt's *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950) the choice reads as a choice for the *katechon*: the cinema as restrainer of an apocalypse photographed before it had happened. The tribute question of Matthew 22 receives its Coen answer. Mannix renders unto Capitol what is Capitol's, and so withholds from the empire of the bomb what it demands. Burt Gurney, the musical star unmasked as a Communist, is carried out to a Soviet submarine with his dog, Engels, and the ransom money goes into the sea. The coin is rendered to no one.

4.6

No Country for Old Men: Aleatory Sovereignty

Anton Chigurh is the corpus's sovereign of the exception in its purest and most perverse form. He decides who lives and dies, recognises no law but his word, and appears and

disappears with the impunity of a natural force. Yet at the moment of decision he abdicates, submitting the choice to a coin. The structure deserves a name: *aleatory sovereignty*, the sovereignty that decides on the exception by refusing to decide. Schmitt's sovereign is defined by the decision; Chigurh's sovereignty consists in transferring the decision to the coin, so that he can claim to be merely its instrument. His weapon confirms the theology. The captive-bolt pistol is a device for stunning cattle before slaughter, and Chigurh uses it on human beings, who thereby enter the category that Giorgio Agamben, reviving an archaic figure of Roman law, called *homo sacer* (1995): the life that may be taken without the taking counting as homicide or as sacrifice. Chigurh kills as one slaughters livestock, and the coin is the slaughterhouse ledger.

Walter Benjamin's 'Zur Kritik der Gewalt' (1921) distinguished mythic violence, which founds and preserves law, is bloody, and demands sacrifice, from divine violence, which destroys law, expiates, and strikes without spilling blood. Chigurh's violence is mythic in Benjamin's exact sense: it enforces a law of Chigurh's own making and exacts its sacrifices one coin at a time. The corpus's nearest image of divine violence is the flood of *O Brother, Where Art Thou?*, which annihilates the scene of an execution the sheriff means to carry out in defiance of a pardon, without shedding blood, and whose agent is at once God and the state. The tornado of *A Serious Man* is its withheld counterpart: divine violence arriving, and cut off before it strikes.

Agamben himself supplies the hinge between this chapter and the Hebrew substrate of Chapter Two. In *Homo Sacer* (1995) he revived Scholem's formula, validity without significance, as the very form of law in the state of exception, a law that remains in force while signifying nothing, and he read Kafka's 'Before the Law' as its parable. The Coen corpus stages both halves of that argument. Rabbi Marshak's closed door is Kafka's; Chigurh's coin is the ban in metal, binding absolutely and meaning nothing at all.

Opposite Chigurh stands Sheriff Bell, the failed katechon, the old lawman whose office was to restrain and who cannot. In the film's most debated scene, Bell returns at night to the El Paso motel room where Llewelyn Moss was killed, the film implies, by cartel gunmen. The lock cylinder has been punched out; the film shows Chigurh, or seems to, waiting in the dark beside the door; Bell enters and finds the room empty, the bathroom window latched, the air-duct cover removed and its screws on the floor beside the coin used to turn them: a dime, the implement Chigurh used to open a vent at an earlier motel. Whether Chigurh was behind the door, whether he has taken the money, the film does not say. The room is in superposition, and the coin that opened the vent is the key to the treasure: the film's last image of the money is an empty duct and a coin on a motel floor.

Two late scenes complete the theology. After Chigurh leaves Carla Jean's house, his car is broadsided at an intersection by another that runs the light: *tuché* strikes the agent of chance. Bleeding, his arm broken, he asks two boys on bicycles for a shirt to make a sling. One offers

it freely. Chigurh insists on paying, presses a bill on him, and as he limps away the boys begin to squabble over the money. The sovereign of the coin cannot receive a gift. He converts the boy's offer into a transaction, and the transaction at once corrupts the bond between the boys. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) described gift economies in which the obligations to give, to receive, and to reciprocate bind a society; Jacques Derrida's *Donner le temps* (1991) argued that the pure gift is impossible because any return, even recognition, annuls it. Chigurh does not merely refuse the gift. He mints it.

4.7

Macbeth's Golden Round

Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth* (2021), made after the brothers' professional divergence, distils the obverse into tragic form. Shot in black and white in a nearly square frame, its castle a geometry of shadow, the film strips Shakespeare's play to its political theology: a crown that Lady Macbeth calls 'the golden round' (I.v), a circle of gold that is the coin of sovereignty, and a prophecy that functions as a divinatory fix. The witches, all embodied by Kathryn Hunter, hail Macbeth as king hereafter, and their salutation behaves like what J. L. Austin called a performative (*How to Do Things with Words*, 1962): an utterance that does what it says, here by coining a king. Macbeth's tragedy is the attempt to fix a future already announced, and it is the exact inverse of Rashi's counsel in *A Serious Man*. Where Rashi forbids the probing of the future, Macbeth probes it and is destroyed by what he learns. The play's most famous speech supplies the obverse its epitaph: life is a tale told by an idiot, full of sound and fury, signifying nothing (V.v). The obverse in its final form is a coin of perfect validity and no significance: the golden round, struck, circulating, and signifying nothing.

The obverse fails throughout the corpus because sovereignty cannot abolish chance; it can only mint it. Every fix is chiselled from within, by a Bernie who leaks the odds, a child who invents a hoop, a word that will not come, a coin that strikes back. The failure of the obverse, however, is only half the story. Its other side is the failure of everyone who is not sovereign to read the signs the sovereign mints.



I returned, and saw under the sun, that the race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong, neither yet bread to the wise, nor yet riches to men of understanding, nor yet favour to men of skill; but time and chance happeneth to them all.

— Ecclesiastes 9:11

CHAPTER FIVE

The Reverse

Monads without Harmony and the Epistemology of Noir

5.1

Monadology Minus Harmony

Leibniz's *Monadology* (1714) describes a universe of simple substances, monads, which have no windows through which anything could enter or depart, and each of which mirrors the whole universe from its own point of view. Their perceptions correspond despite their isolation because God established among them a harmony from the beginning, as a clockmaker might set two clocks to strike together. Coen noir is the *Monadology* with the harmony subtracted. Its characters are windowless: each perceives the world from a point of view that includes false beliefs about the others, and none can enter another's perspective to correct them. Without pre-established harmony their clocks do not strike together, and the plot is the sum of their non-correspondence.

The opening monologue of the brothers' first film announces the subtraction. Over images of empty Texas landscape, the private detective Loren Visser contrasts the Soviet Union, where everything is planned so that everyone pulls for everyone else, with Texas, where you are on your own; the world, he says, is full of complainers, but the fact is that nothing comes with a guarantee. A guarantee is the commercial name for pre-established harmony: a warranty that the world will correspond to its description. *Blood Simple* is set in a country where the warranties have been voided.

5.2

Blood Simple: Four Windowless Rooms

Each of *Blood Simple*'s four principals acts on a false picture of the others. Julian Marty, a bar owner, believes his wife Abby and his bartender Ray are lovers, correctly, and hires Visser to kill them. Visser photographs the couple asleep, doctors the photograph to show them dead, collects his fee, and shoots Marty with Abby's pistol. Ray finds Marty apparently dead, assumes Abby killed him, cleans up, and buries Marty alive. Abby takes Ray's strange behaviour for betrayal. In the final sequence, as Visser stalks her through her apartment, Abby, believing her attacker to be Marty, shoots him through a door and tells him she is not afraid of him, Marty, while Visser lies laughing and dying beneath a washbasin. No character ever holds the true picture; the only one who sees all of it is the spectator, in the position the *Monadology* reserves for God. Two objects circulate through the film as signs that are never read: the doctored photograph, a counterfeit image of a death that has not occurred, and Visser's lighter, left on Marty's desk beneath a dead fish, the one piece of evidence that would reveal everything and that no one takes up. The lighter is engraved with an honour, Man of the Year, the very title Visser's opening monologue had listed among the dignities that nothing guarantees: the unread sign is a medal, an inscription of worth left to rot beneath the catch. The title, from Hammett's *Red Harvest* (1929), names the state of mind that violence induces: a simplicity of blood, in which the monads' windows are painted over.

5.3

Fargo: The Liar's Frame

Fargo opens with a title card stating that it is a true story, that the events took place in Minnesota in 1987, that names have been changed at the request of the survivors, and that, out of respect for the dead, the rest has been told exactly as it occurred. It is not true, and the end credits carry the customary disclaimer that the persons and events portrayed are fictitious. The film is framed by contradictory performatives, a version of the liar paradox attributed to Epimenides of Crete. The opening claim operates as what Roland Barthes called the reality effect ('L'effet de réel', 1968): a detail, here a declaration, whose only signified is the category

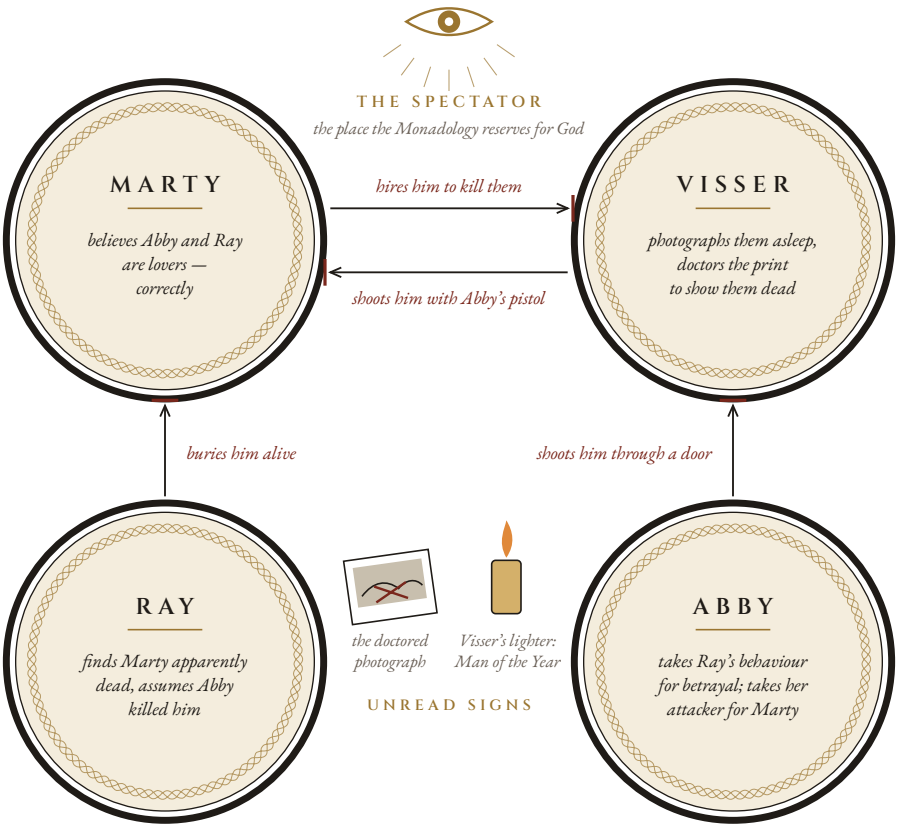


FIG. 7 Four windowless rooms. Each of *Blood Simple*'s principals acts on a false picture of the others; every act stops at a wall. Between them lie the two signs no one reads, and only the spectator, in the position Leibniz reserves for God, holds the whole.

of the real. The Coens promote the reality effect from ornament to title card and so expose its structure, which is fiduciary: the audience accepts the claim as it accepts paper money, on the credit of the issuer. The claim also proved capable, in the manner Borges imagined in 'Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius' (1940), of colonising reality. On 15 November 2001 the body of Takako Konishi, a twenty-eight-year-old office worker from Tokyo, was found by a hunter in a field near Detroit Lakes, Minnesota; her death was ruled a suicide. Days earlier, in Bismarck, North Dakota, she had spent hours with a police officer who could not follow her halting English; a colleague who had seen *Fargo* told him that money was buried in the film, and the story that she had come to find it reached the world's press. It was false. The filmmaker Paul Berczeller, retracing her journey, found that her connection to the region was personal rather than cinematic, and he called his documentary *This Is a True Story* (2003). The title repeats *Fargo*'s card word for word, and the repetition makes it true: Pierre

Menard's method (Chapters Eight and Nine) applied to a fiat declaration, the same words reissued by a different issuer and, this time, backed. The legend went on to a fiction of its own, David and Nathan Zellner's *Kumiko, the Treasure Hunter* (2014). The counterfeit title card minted a counterfeit legend, and the legend overwrote a real woman's death with the film's MacGuffin; it took the identical sentence, honestly issued, to redeem it.

The film's hermeneutic hero is Marge Gunderson, and her method is what Peirce called abduction: inference to a hypothesis that would, if true, render surprising facts a matter of course. Umberto Eco and Thomas Sebeok's *The Sign of Three* (1983) traced the detective's abductive reasoning from Dupin and Holmes to Peirce, and Marge belongs in its gallery. Her decisive inference concerns three letters. The murdered state trooper had begun to record the stopped car's plate in his ticket book as 'DLR'. Marge recognises that the letters are not a plate number but an abbreviation: dealer plates, the temporary tags of a car taken from a lot. Her insight turns on a distinction Peirce made central to semiotics, between type and token. The investigators had mistaken a type, the class of dealer cars, for a token, an individual number, and the case turns on recognising that a sign which appears to name an individual names a class.

Marge's education in counterfeits proceeds through the film's most apparently gratuitous episode. Mike Yanagita, a high-school acquaintance, invites her to a hotel restaurant in Minneapolis, tells her that his wife, a mutual classmate, has died of leukaemia, and breaks down. Marge later learns from a friend that the wife is alive and that Mike has been unwell and invented the story. Critics often treat the scene as a digression. It is the film's hinge. Mike's counterfeit grief teaches Marge that a sympathetic face can circulate a false story, and the next morning she returns, unbidden, to question Jerry Lundegaard again. The scene is a counterfeit coin that trains the detective to detect counterfeits, set inside a film whose own title card is counterfeit.

Fargo's landscape is the visual correlate of its epistemology. The film opens in a whiteout from which a car emerges as from a blank page. In 'The Whiteness of the Whale' (*Moby-Dick*, 1851, chapter 42), Melville asks whether it is because whiteness is the visible absence of colour that there is 'such a dumb blankness, full of meaning, in a wide landscape of snows', a colourless all-colour of atheism from which we shrink. The snow of *Fargo* is that blankness, and it erases every sign entrusted to it. When Carl Showalter buries the ransom beside a highway fence, he marks the spot with an ice scraper and then looks along the fence, which runs without differentiation to the horizon. The sign is lost not because it is destroyed but because it is identical to every other. Seriality is the snow's other name. Over this landscape presides the giant statue of Paul Bunyan at the edge of Brainerd, emblem of the American tall tale, the folk form of the title card's lie.

5.4

The Purloined Letter, Revised

Lacan's 'Séminaire sur "La Lettre volée"' (1956) read Poe's tale as an allegory of the signifier: a letter whose content is never disclosed determines, by its displacements, the positions of everyone who holds it, and the seminar concludes that a letter always arrives at its destination. Derrida's reply, 'Le facteur de la vérité' (1975), objected that a letter can always fail to arrive, and that this possibility of non-arrival belongs to the structure of the letter itself. The Coen corpus sides with Derrida so consistently that the preference amounts to a doctrine. *Fargo*'s money stays in the snow. *No Country*'s vanishes into a duct. *The Big Lebowski*'s ransom never existed. *Hail, Caesar!*'s goes into the sea. In *Burn After Reading*, the disc two gym employees hope to sell reaches the Russian embassy, whose officials find it worthless: the letter arrives at a destination that does not want it. Only *The Hudsucker Proxy*'s blue letter reaches its addressee, and only by angelic intervention and the stopping of time. The Coen theology of the letter fits in a sentence: letters arrive only by miracle, and miracles require the clock to stop.

5.5

Burn After Reading: The Institution That Does Not Know

Burn After Reading (2008) is the *Monadology* as farce, and its distinctive contribution is to extend the windowless condition from persons to the institution charged with knowing. Osbourne Cox, an analyst demoted for drinking, quits the Central Intelligence Agency and begins a memoir of no value. A disc containing a draft turns up on the floor of a gym called Hardbodies, where two employees, Linda Litzke, who needs money for cosmetic surgery, and Chad Feldheimer, an amiable fool, take it for raw intelligence. A federal marshal who boasts of never having fired his weapon shoots Chad dead in a closet; Osbourne kills an innocent man with a hatchet. The coda takes place at Langley. A senior officer hears a subordinate's report of these events and asks, in substance, what they have learned; the answer is that they have learned not to do it again, though neither man can say what it was they did. The film's last joke is the confession of the big Other. Lacan's formula that the big Other does not exist, that there is no guarantor of the symbolic order who knows what the subject does not, receives its institutional illustration. The intelligence agency does not know, and it orders the matter buried.

The title names a hermeneutic imperative: read, then destroy. It is the instruction stamped on classified documents and a figure for the Coen sign, which is consumed in the act of being read. Derrida's *Feu la cendre* (1987) meditates on the phrase 'il y a là cendre', there are cinders there, as the trace of a writing that has burned; the Coen sign is such a cinder, a meaning that survives only as ash. The film opened in American cinemas on 12

September 2008. Three days later Lehman Brothers filed for bankruptcy, and the financial system discovered that its own raw intelligence, the ratings and models that priced its assets, was worth about as much as Osbourne Cox's memoir.

5.6

The Man Who Wasn't There: Invisibility, Uncertainty, and the Two Goats

Ed Crane, a barber in Santa Rosa, California, in 1949, is the corpus's most perfectly windowless monad. He speaks little, smokes constantly, and moves through the film like a man already absent from it. In the second book of the *Republic* (359c–360d), Glaucon tells of Gyges, who found a ring that made him invisible and used it to commit injustice with impunity, and asks whether anyone so empowered would remain just. Ed is Gyges without the ring, invisible by temperament. He blackmails his wife's lover, Big Dave Brewster, to finance a dry-cleaning venture proposed by a travelling entrepreneur; kills Big Dave when the blackmail is discovered and Dave attacks him; and watches his wife charged with the killing. The title is literal. Ed is the man who was not there, neither seen by others nor, in any robust sense, present to himself. Critics have rightly compared him to Camus's Meursault (*L'Étranger*, 1942), and the comparison sharpens at the end. Meursault, on the eve of execution, opens himself to the tender indifference of the world; Ed, strapped into the electric chair, hopes that he may find his wife wherever he is going and tell her the things for which there are no words here. His is a Tractarian hope: that what cannot be said in this world may show itself in another (*TLP* 6.522).

The dry-cleaning venture is the film's sacramental joke. Dry cleaning is cleansing without water, a purification that dispenses with the element of baptism. Ed invests ten thousand dollars of blackmail money in it, and the entrepreneur, Creighton Tolliver, is a con man: absolution privatised and counterfeited. Freddy Riedenschneider, the costly lawyer hired for Doris's defence, invokes the uncertainty principle and proposes to build reasonable doubt upon it. The trial never reaches a verdict. Before it can open, Doris takes her own life in her cell, and the autopsy discloses a pregnancy that cannot have been Ed's. Ed is later convicted of Tolliver's murder, which Big Dave committed. The structure is Leviticus 16: two goats before the altar, each condemned for the other's act, the lot falling without regard to deed. The precision matters. The lot never falls on Doris, who removes herself from the lottery before it can be cast; and the autopsy completes the film's monadology, since even the body of the person nearest to Ed held a fact he could not have known.

The film's imagery is numismatic in a literal sense, for it is crowded with discs. When Birdy Abundas, the teenage pianist whose career Ed hopes to sponsor, makes a sexual advance toward him in his car and he refuses it, the car crashes, and in slow motion a hubcap

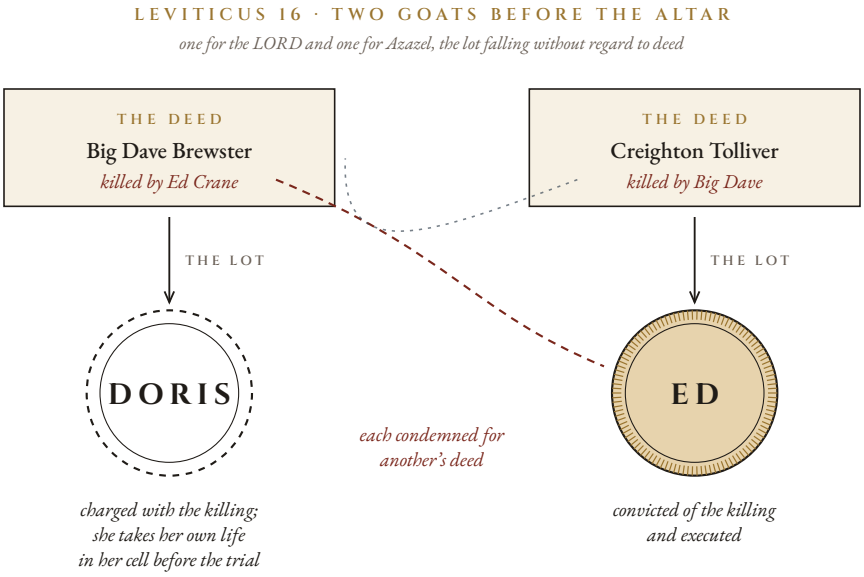


FIG. 8 The lottery of the two goats (Leviticus 16) in *The Man Who Wasn't There*. Ed Crane kills Big Dave, and Doris is charged; Big Dave kills Tolliver, and Ed is executed for it. The lot never falls on Doris, who removes herself before it can be cast.

rolls across the road toward him, on its edge. The refusal is among the few unforced ethical acts Ed performs, and it is at that instant that a disc stands on its rim. Later, in the prison yard, Ed sees, or dreams that he sees, a flying saucer hovering above him. The rolling hubcap and the hovering saucer are coins on their edges, discs that have fallen to neither face. They mark the film's only openings toward the edge, and both arrive with catastrophe or delusion. In *The Man Who Wasn't There*, the edge is glimpsed only by a man about to die.

5.7

Coda: Cannes, 2001

At the 2001 Cannes Film Festival the prize for direction was shared between Joel Coen, for *The Man Who Wasn't There*, and David Lynch, for *Mulholland Drive*. The conjunction invites a comparison that clarifies the Coens' metaphysics by contrast. Lynch's cinema is a metaphysics of depth. Beneath the surface of American normality lies another order, the Black Lodge of *Twin Peaks* or the blue box of *Mulholland Drive*, a realm of real if unintelligible forces in which good and evil carry ontological weight; Slavoj Žižek's study of *Lost Highway*, *The Art of the Ridiculous Sublime* (2000), describes Lynch's uncanny collisions

of the banal and the transcendent. The Coens' cinema is a metaphysics of surface. There is nothing beneath, for the coin has no inside. Their sublime, if it is one, is numismatic rather than ridiculous. A wood chipper in a Minnesota yard terrifies not because it opens onto another world but because it opens onto nothing: onto the plain fact of a body reduced to material in an exchange for money. Lynch's characters fall through the surface into depth. The Coens' slide across it, and their only escape lies not downward but sideways, onto the edge.

Gilles Deleuze's *Cinéma 1: L'image-mouvement* (1983) and *Cinéma 2: L'image-temps* (1985) describe a post-war crisis of the action-image: the loosening of the sensory-motor link that had bound perception to action in classical cinema, so that characters become seers rather than agents, placed in situations to which they can no longer respond, in what Deleuze called any-space-whatever (*espace quelconque*). The Coens stage this crisis inside the action-image's own genres. Their noirs, westerns, and gangster films keep the machinery of action and fill it with seers, the Dude, Ed Crane, Larry Gopnik, Llewyn Davis, who look, register, and fail to act, in bowling alleys, motels, barbershops, and parking lots that function as any-space-whatever. The coin is the action-image's last resort: when perception no longer issues in action, a toss supplies the act.



I would prefer not to.

— Herman Melville, 'Bartleby, the Scrivener' (1853)

CHAPTER SIX

The Edge, I

Abiding, Uselessness, and the Pure Fool

6.1

The Edge Defined

The edge is neither the synthesis of obverse and reverse nor a compromise between them. It is the improbable outcome in which a value declines to be decided: a coin that comes to rest, against the odds, on its rim, and so belongs neither to the sovereign who stamped it nor to the chance that tossed it. In the ethical register, the edge names a mode of being that neither fixes nor gambles, neither rules nor submits, and that therefore escapes, for a time, the economy of the coin. It is unstable, holding only while the coin balances or rolls. The figures who occupy it in the Coen corpus are few, and they are not heroes in any conventional sense. They are idlers and fools, a pregnant police chief, a fourteen-year-old girl, a widow, a cat. This chapter follows the figures of abiding and uselessness; the next follows the figures of the ledger and the gift.

6.2

The Dude: The Useless Tree

The Dude's ethics begins in uselessness. The *Zhuangzi* tells of a master carpenter who passes a gigantic oak without a glance, explaining to his apprentice that its wood is worthless, that a coffin made from it would rot and a door would ooze sap, and that it has lived so long precisely because it is good for nothing. That night the tree appears to the carpenter in a dream and asks whether he would compare it to the fruit trees whose branches are broken because they bear, adding that it has long sought to be useless (*Zhuangzi*, chapter 4). Jeffrey Lebowski, who calls himself the Dude, is the useless tree of Los Angeles. He has no job and no ambition; his politics consist of memories of the Port Huron Statement and the Seattle Seven; his possessions of note are a car, a bathrobe, and a rug. Everyone in the film attempts to use him. The millionaire whose name he shares employs him as a courier for a ransom; the millionaire's daughter, Maude, recruits him as the father of a child she means to raise alone; nihilists, a pornographer, and a private detective all mistake him for an instrument. None succeeds. He survives the film's violence as the tree survives the carpenter, by being good for nothing.

Four traditions converge on the Dude's verb, 'abide'. The Daoist *wu wei*, non-coercive action, describes an agency that accomplishes by not forcing. Martin Heidegger's *Gelassenheit* (1959), releasement toward things, describes an attitude that lets beings be without seizing them as resources. Qoheleth, whose counsel in a world of *hevel* is to eat one's bread with joy and drink one's wine with a merry heart (Ecclesiastes 9:7), describes a joy that does not mistake vapour for substance; the Dude's White Russians are Qoheleth's wine. And Melville's Bartleby, whose formula 'I would prefer not to' Gilles Deleuze read as a grammatical anomaly that hollows out the language of preference ('Bartleby, ou la formule', 1989) and Giorgio Agamben as the figure of a pure potentiality, the potential not to ('Bartleby, o della contingenza', 1993), supplies the fourth. The Dude's abiding is a preference not to: not to join the millionaire's scheme, not to fear the nihilists, not to solve the case. His survival through uselessness is the corpus's strongest evidence that the edge can be inhabited.

The rug tests that habitation. A thug sent to collect a debt owed by the wrong Lebowski urinates on it, and the Dude's quest begins with his insistence that it really tied the room together. The rug is what Heidegger, in 'Das Ding' (1950), called a thing: not an object but a gathering, an item around which a dwelling is assembled and held, as a jug gathers earth and sky, mortals and gods. The Dude seeks compensation, and in seeking it he enters the economy. The millionaire refuses him; he leaves with a rug from the mansion anyway; the replacement, being fungible, ties the room together as well as the first; then it, too, is taken away, reclaimed by Maude's men. The rug's history is the history of use-value overtaken by exchange-value (Marx, *Das Kapital*, 1867, chapter 1). The thing that gathered a dwelling becomes a commodity, and the commodity is repossessed. The Dude's fall is not into sin

but into the economy, and his return to abiding is the recovery of uselessness after the failure of compensation.

The film's mythic armature is the Grail cycle as T. S. Eliot inherited it from Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920). The Big Lebowski is a Fisher King: a wounded and impotent ruler, confined to a wheelchair in a Pasadena mansion, whose fortune belongs to his late wife and whose charitable foundation he has been quietly robbing. The land he presides over, Los Angeles at the time of the Gulf War, is Eliot's waste land, a city of bowling alleys, pornographers, and indifferent police. The Dude is Perceval, Wagner's *reine Tor* (*Parsifal*, 1882), the pure fool who enters the castle without understanding where he is. In Chrétien de Troyes and Wolfram von Eschenbach, Perceval fails at his first visit to ask the question that would heal the king; the Dude asks no question the plot can use. Maude, who seduces him in order to conceive, is a Kundry, the ambiguous woman who both tempts and serves the Grail. And the Grail itself has been replaced by a briefcase of laundry and a severed toe offered as proof of a kidnapping that never occurred: a fetish in the precise sense of Freud's 'Fetischismus' (1927), a substitute for a missing part. Jean-Joseph Goux's *Économie et symbolique* (1973) argued that gold, the father, the phallus, and the monarch occupy homologous positions as general equivalents in their respective economies. *The Big Lebowski* is a comedy of the collapse of all four at once. The father is impotent; the money is fake; the toe belongs to someone else; the nihilists threaten to cut off the Dude's 'johnson'; and the monarch's voice, the president's declaration that this aggression will not stand, survives only as a phrase the Dude repeats.

Walter Sobchak is the film's Don Quixote. Like Cervantes's knight (1605, 1615), he lives inside a romance, Vietnam rather than chivalry, and imposes its codes on a world that does not recognise them; his assault with a crowbar on the red sports car of an innocent neighbour, mistaken for the property of the teenage car thief, is the corpus's tilt at a windmill. Miguel de Unamuno's *Vida de Don Quijote y Sancho* (1905) read the knight as a holy madman whose folly exposes the world's sanity as cowardice, and Walter's absurd fidelities, to an ex-wife whose dog he still minds, to a faith adopted for her sake, to a war long over, carry the same double edge. The Dude is his Sancho: corporeal, sceptical, loyal. The film's nihilists, by contrast, are counterfeit Nietzscheans. They proclaim that they believe in nothing and demand the money anyway, and Walter's riposte, that whatever one thinks of National Socialism, at least it is an ethos, lands because it exposes their nihilism as greed with a German accent. Nietzsche cast the theologians and priests he despised as forgers and falsifiers, as the paragraph that follows sets out; in the register of this dissertation they are counterfeiters (*Falschmünzer*), coiners of false values; the nihilists of *The Big Lebowski* are counterfeiters of the counterfeit, whose nihilism is itself a currency of extortion.

Nietzsche's charge is explicit in *Der Antichrist* (written 1888, published 1895): the theological instinct is 'the most widespread and the most subterranean form of falsehood

to be found on earth' (§9), and priestly scripture a forgery manufactured to secure priestly power (§26). The numismatic reading renders forgery as counterfeiting, and the nihilists of the bowling alley, who believe in nothing and still want the money, are its most comic late instance.

The film's other bowler with a sacred name completes its catalogue of counterfeit holiness. Jesus Quintana, a rival in the league, is identified by the Dude as a convicted sex offender who served time for exposing himself to an eight-year-old and was required to inform his neighbours. He bears the Saviour's name and treats his bowling ball like a relic: the corpus's first counterfeit Christ, a predator under a holy name, whose figure returns decades later in Reverend Drew Devlin, the corrupt cult leader of the Four-Way Temple in Ethan Coen's *Honey Don't!*.

Donny dies not of the nihilists' violence but of a heart attack during their confrontation in a parking lot: of *tuché*, not of plot. The funeral home's price for an urn offends Walter, who buys a coffee can instead, and on a bluff above the Pacific, after a eulogy that wanders from Donny's love of bowling to the battlefields of Vietnam, he shakes out the ashes into a wind that blows them back over the Dude. The image is Qoheleth's governing word made visible. *Hevel*, rendered 'vanity' by the King James Version, means breath or vapour, and Qoheleth's refrain, 'vanity and vexation of spirit' (Ecclesiastes 1:14), can equally be read as vapour and a striving after wind. Donny's ashes are vapour returning on the wind: the most literal illustration of Ecclesiastes in American cinema, and a rite that Wittgenstein's 'Remarks on Frazer' teaches us to read as expression rather than error.

The film is framed by the narration of the Stranger, a cowboy who appears at the bar of the bowling alley and addresses the audience directly. He is a chorus in the strict sense of Old Comedy: his interventions are a *parabasis*, the moment in Aristophanes when the chorus steps forward and speaks to the audience in the poet's name. Friedrich Schlegel defined irony as a permanent parabasis, and Paul de Man took the phrase as the definition of irony as such ('The Concept of Irony', 1977). The Stranger is Coen irony personified, and his last speech is a blessing. He confesses that he did not like seeing Donny go; he takes comfort in knowing that the Dude is out there, takin' 'er easy for all us sinners; he calls the whole affair the human comedy; and he reports that there is a little Lebowski on the way. The phrase 'for all us sinners' gives the Dude's abiding a vicarious structure. He takes it easy on our behalf, as the servant of Isaiah 'bare the sin of many' (Isaiah 53:12). The Dude is the corpus's comic redeemer, and his redemption is idleness.

The film's afterlife confirms the reading. Dudeism, founded in 2005, ordains its priests online; the Lebowski Fest, since 2002, gathers celebrants in costume to bowl and recite. The religion founded on the film is knowingly fictional, a living instance of what Kurt Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) called *foma*, harmless untruths that make people brave and

kind and healthy and happy. That a film about abiding should have generated a church of abiding is evidence for the numismatic thesis: emptied forms, attended to, refill.

Umberto Eco argued that a cult film must be 'unhinged', loose enough to be broken into detachable scenes and lines that its devotees can inhabit apart from the whole ('Casablanca: Cult Movies and Intertextual Collage', 1984). *The Big Lebowski* is unhinged in exactly this sense. Its lines circulate apart from the film as coins circulate apart from the mint, and its cult is the numismatic thesis enacted by an audience.

6.3

O Brother, Where Art Thou?: Nostos and the Dialectic of Enlightenment

O Brother, Where Art Thou? (2000) transposes Homer's *Odyssey* to Depression-era Mississippi, and the brothers' much-repeated claim in interviews never to have read the poem belongs to their repertoire of masks: the correspondences are too exact to be accidental and too playful to be scholarly. Everett Ulysses McGill escapes a chain gang with two companions to recover, he says, a buried treasure before his wife, Penny, remarries. The trio meet a blind seer on a railroad handcar who prophesies that they will find a fortune, though not the one they seek; sirens who seduce them at a river; a one-eyed Bible salesman, Big Dan Teague, who robs them; a governor named Menelaus 'Pappy' O'Daniel; and a reform candidate named Homer Stokes who is unmasked as the Grand Wizard of the Ku Klux Klan. The title comes from Preston Sturges's *Sullivan's Travels* (1941), whose director-hero longs to make a socially conscious epic of that name before learning that the poor need laughter more than sermons. The Coens make Sullivan's film as Sturges's moral says it should be made: as a comedy.

The treasure does not exist. Everett invented it to persuade the men he was chained to to escape with him, since he needed to reach home before Penny's wedding. The film's MacGuffin is counterfeit from the start, a beetle-box with nothing in it, and its supposed site lies in a valley the state is about to flood for a hydroelectric reservoir. The film is set in 1937, four years after Executive Order 6102 required Americans to surrender their gold coin and bullion to the Federal Reserve; the treasure is doubly fictitious, a hoard of gold in a country whose private gold had been recalled.

The climax stages the dialectic of enlightenment with a precision Horkheimer and Adorno might have admired. The three men are captured by Sheriff Cooley, a figure of implacable pursuit with dark glasses and a hound, whom the film aligns with the devil that Tommy Johnson, a young Black guitarist, describes having met at the crossroads, and they are about to be hanged at the site of the treasure. Everett, the trio's rationalist, who has mocked his companions' superstitions and their baptism, kneels and prays. The valley

floods, the hanging is prevented, and the men float free. Everett at once explains the miracle as the work of the Tennessee Valley Authority and announces the coming of electricity and the age of reason. The film does not adjudicate. The flood is at once a deus ex machina, an answered prayer, and a public works project, and the impossibility of telling them apart is the film's theology: in modernity miracle and modernisation coincide, and the enlightenment that explains the miracle cannot explain why it arrived at the moment of prayer. Max Weber's disenchantment of the world (*Wissenschaft als Beruf*, 1919) meets here a comic objection, not because the world is enchanted, but because the disenchanted explanation does not exhaust the event. Even that explanation is a fiction. The film's reservoir is modelled on Arkabutla Lake in north Mississippi, which was built not by the Tennessee Valley Authority but by the Army Corps of Engineers under the Flood Control Act of 1937: the enlightened account of the miracle credits the wrong sovereign.

Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) describes the modern 'immanent frame', within which belief and unbelief are both live options and each is cross-pressured by the other. The Coens' characters live inside that frame and are cross-pressured by events, a flood, a tornado, a saucer, a dream, that the frame can explain and cannot quite contain. Everett's instant lecture on hydroelectric power is the immanent frame closing over a miracle a moment too late.

Two further details belong to the edge. The trio's rescue of Tommy Johnson from a Ku Klux Klan rally, at which Klansmen led by the reform candidate Homer Stokes are preparing to lynch him, is staged as a parody of the Winkie guards' march in *The Wizard of Oz* (1939), and it folds the Faustian bargain into the Odyssean return: Tommy has sold his soul at a crossroads for mastery of the guitar, a legend the blues attached to the historical Tommy Johnson before it attached to Robert Johnson. The sequence binds electoral sovereignty to the lynch mob: the reform candidate is the Grand Wizard, and the noose the Klan prepares for a Black musician anticipates the gallows Sheriff Cooley prepares for the three white convicts, from which only the flood delivers them. Girard's scapegoat here takes its American historical form, the lynching of Black Southerners by white mobs under Jim Crow, and the film names it by staging it. And the return itself turns on a ring. Penny will remarry Everett only if he recovers her original wedding ring, which lies in a rolltop desk in the cabin now at the bottom of the reservoir. Penny refuses fungibility: she wants that ring, not a ring. Where the Dude's rug could be replaced, Penny's ring cannot, and her insistence on the irreplaceable is the edge's demand in its most domestic form. As the family walks through town, the blind seer passes on his handcar. The ring, a circle, the coin's edge made jewellery, remains under water.

6.4

Inside Llewyn Davis: Repetition without Return

Inside Llewyn Davis (2013) is an odyssey without nostos. Its hero is a folk singer in Greenwich Village in 1961, loosely modelled on Dave Van Ronk, whose posthumous memoir *The Mayor of MacDougal Street* (2005) records the milieu the film recreates. He spends a week sleeping on couches, learning that a friend's partner is pregnant and possibly by him, losing and finding and losing a cat, travelling to Chicago to audition for an impresario, and returning to the Gaslight Café to be beaten in an alley, which is where the film began. The structure is a loop: the opening scene recurs at the end, now disclosed in a fuller context. Kierkegaard's *Gjentagelsen* (*Repetition*, 1843), published under the pseudonym Constantin Constantius, recounts its narrator's attempt to repeat a happy journey to Berlin, which fails because nothing recurs as it was; Kierkegaard distinguishes the Greek recollection, which repeats backward, from a repetition forward that only the religious can achieve. Llewyn's week is recollection without repetition, a return to its beginning without renewal. The loop is nonetheless not identical. In the final sequence, as Llewyn is beaten outside, a young singer plainly meant as Bob Dylan takes the stage inside and sings 'Farewell', a song commentators trace to the traditional 'Leaving of Liverpool': the new voice that displaces Llewyn is itself a common tune reissued under a single name. Gilles Deleuze argued in *Différence et répétition* (1968) that repetition is the ground from which difference is produced. Llewyn's repetition is the ground of another's difference, the stalled cycle on which history advances without him.

The film's true Ulysses is a cat. Llewyn takes charge of an orange tomcat belonging to his academic friends the Gorfeins, loses it, finds a cat he believes to be it, discovers that it is female and not theirs, abandons it in a car in the snow, and on the road back from Chicago strikes a cat and watches it limp into the woods. Meanwhile the Gorfeins' cat, whose name is Ulysses, has made its way home alone. In a cinema lobby Llewyn passes a poster for Disney's *The Incredible Journey* (1963), a film about pets crossing a continent to return home, and is undone. The cat completes the nostos its keeper cannot. Joseph Campbell's monomyth (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949), departure, initiation, and return with a boon, is enacted in full only by an animal. Llewyn departs, undergoes his trial before a king, the impresario Bud Grossman, who hears him sing and tells him that he does not see a lot of money there, and returns with nothing.

Llewyn's relation to money is the film's numismatic core. Earlier in the week he plays on a novelty recording, 'Please Mr. Kennedy', and, needing cash at once, signs away his royalties for a flat session fee on a song the film plainly marks for success. The choice between fee and royalty is the choice between the coin in hand and a share in an uncertain future. Llewyn chooses the coin, and the film registers his choice as the closing of the one door the week opened. His former partner, Mike, survives only as a voice on a record; Mike took his own

life by leaping from the George Washington Bridge, and his suicide is the grief the film approaches only obliquely and the reason Llewyn now performs alone; the week's whole economy of loss, the lost cat, the lost royalties, the lost partner, is organised around a death the film barely names. The drive to Chicago, through a frozen night beside a heroin-addicted jazz musician and a silent driver, has the shape of a Dantean descent toward the circle of ice; and the cat named Ulysses, who returns, is the plant of the *Epic of Gilgamesh* that, for once, the serpent did not steal.

6.5

Raising Arizona: The Effective Dreamer

Raising Arizona (1987) is the corpus's first comedy of the edge, and its hero is a dreamer whose dreams take effect. H. I. McDunnough, a recidivist convenience-store robber, and his wife Ed, the police officer who took his mugshots, learn that they cannot have a child and steal one of the five quintuplets born to the furniture magnate Nathan Arizona. The theft is a comedy of seriality: confronted with five nearly identical infants, H.I. cannot settle which to take, for the babies are tokens of one type, coins of a single denomination. Later H.I. dreams of a demonic biker, the Lone Biker of the Apocalypse, and the biker, Leonard Smalls, then enters the waking world as a bounty hunter. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), whose title comes from the *Zhuangzi*, imagines a man whose dreams alter reality and whose Daoist passivity is set against the will to control of the psychiatrist who would use his gift to improve the world. H.I. is Le Guin's George Orr with a prison record, a man whose dreams have effects he cannot master.

The film ends with a dream of the future. H.I. sees Nathan Junior, returned to his parents, grown into a football player; sees an old couple, perhaps himself and Ed, visited by children and grandchildren; and wonders whether this was Utah, a land where all parents are strong and wise and capable and all children happy and beloved. Ernst Bloch's *Das Prinzip Hoffnung* (1954–59) called such images anticipatory illumination (*Vor-Schein*): the daydream in which a good not yet existing shows itself in advance and so becomes a real force in the present. H.I.'s Utah is the corpus's first Blochian utopia, and its tentativeness, 'maybe it was Utah', is its honesty. At the corpus's beginning, the edge is a dream from which the dreamer must wake. Twenty years later, *No Country for Old Men* would end with another.



The wicked flee when no man pursueth: but the righteous are bold as a lion.

— Proverbs 28:1

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Edge, II

The Ledger, the Gift, and the Comedies of the Con

7.1

True Grit: The Ledger and Grace

True Grit (2010) states its theology in its narrator's first speech. Mattie Ross, recalling from middle age the winter when, at fourteen, she set out to avenge her father's murder, observes that one must pay for everything in this world, one way and another, and that there is nothing free except the grace of God. The sentence, taken from Charles Portis's novel, divides the cosmos into two economies: a ledger, in which every act incurs a debt that must be paid, and a gift, the grace that alone is unearned. Max Weber traced in *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–05) the Calvinist anxiety in which the believer, unable to know whether he is elect, seeks signs of election in methodical labour and the scrupulous keeping of accounts. Mattie, a Presbyterian of formidable scriptural fluency and a negotiator of genius, is Weber's Calvinist at fourteen. Her first triumph is not a gunfight but a transaction: she bullies the horse trader Colonel Stonehill into buying back the ponies

her father had purchased and paying for a horse stolen from his stable, through threats of litigation by her attorney, J. Noble Daggett. The crime that sets the film in motion is itself an entry in a ledger. Tom Chaney shot Frank Ross and took his life, his horse, and two California gold pieces that he carried in his trouser band. In Portis's novel the coins were a wedding gift from Mattie's grandfather, so that the ledger opens with a gift turned into loot. Restitution, when it comes, is partial: Rooster recovers one of the coins, and in the novel the other is never found.

The ledger organises the film's justice. At a public hanging in Fort Smith, three condemned men are permitted last words, and the ledger contains an erasure: the two white men speak, and the third, a Native American, is hooded before he can say anything. The film records the inequality without comment; the face denied speech is the ethical scandal Levinas placed at the origin of ethics. Rooster Cogburn's testimony at a trial becomes, under cross-examination, an accounting of the men he has shot in the line of duty, the total disputed, the kills itemised. Mattie's retribution against Chaney is completed when, having shot him, she is thrown by the rifle's recoil into a pit of rattlesnakes; she is bitten, and the price is her arm. One must pay for everything.

Against the ledger stands one act that exceeds it. After the bite, Rooster lifts Mattie onto her pony, Little Blackie, and rides through the night toward a doctor, driving the horse until it founders and then, when it can go no farther, shooting it and carrying the girl on foot beneath the stars. Rooster has been paid; his contract with Mattie was fulfilled when Chaney fell. The ride is not owed. It is the one act in the film that cannot be entered in the ledger, and it costs a life, the pony's, which the film mourns. Marcel Mauss's gift, which obligates a return, and Jacques Derrida's pure gift, which must not appear as a gift lest recognition repay it, mark the two limits between which Rooster's ride falls: he never speaks of it, and Mattie learns its cost only afterward. The epilogue, twenty-five years later, completes the economy. Mattie, unmarried and one-armed, travels to meet Rooster at a Wild West show and learns that he died three days before; she has his remains moved and reburied in her family plot. The reburial is fidelity, the edge's form in the moral register: a nostos for the dead, granted by the one he carried. The score, built on the hymn 'Leaning on the Everlasting Arms' (1887), recalls Charles Laughton's *The Night of the Hunter* (1955), in which the same hymn sets the faith of a guardian of children against a preacher who preys on them.

7.2

The Ballad of Buster Scruggs: A Book of the Dead

The Coens' last joint feature presents six Western tales as the pages of an illustrated book, turned by a hand at the start of each episode, its colour plates prefiguring scenes to come. Walter Benjamin's 'Der Erzähler' (1936) argued that the storyteller borrows his authority from death, which is the sanction of everything he can tell. *The Ballad of Buster Scruggs*



AN ACCOUNT

kept, after the manner of Mattie Ross

ACCOUNT	PAID	REMARKS
Frank Ross	*his life; his horse; two California gold pieces*	*shot by Tom Chaney*
Col. Stonehill	*the ponies bought back; the stolen horse*	*paid for, under threat of litigation*
Fort Smith gallows	*last words: two men speak*	*the third is hooded before he can*
Rooster Cogburn	*the men he has shot, itemised on the stand*	*the total disputed*
Tom Chaney	*his life*	*shot by Mattie*
Mattie Ross	*an arm*	*the recoil, the pit, the rattlesnakes*
Little Blackie	*his life*	*driven till he founders, then shot*
The ride	CANNOT BE ENTERED	*not owed*

FIG. 9 The ledger of *True Grit*. One must pay for everything, and the film keeps the account: a father, a horse and two gold pieces; an arm; a pony. Rooster's ride is the one entry that cannot be made, because it is not owed.

(2018) makes that sanction its organising principle, for each tale ends in a death or a near death, and the last is set on a stagecoach whose passengers are, it gradually appears, travelling toward their own.

The first tale's hero, a singing gunslinger in white, takes a seat at a poker table just vacated by a player who has walked away from the hand he was dealt: aces and eights, the dead man's hand associated with Wild Bill Hickok. The table insists that, having seen the cards, Buster must play them; he declines to inherit another man's fate, and a shootout follows. Later Buster is outdrawn by a younger gunman in black and ascends on angel's wings, singing a duet with his killer: kitsch transcendence, a counterfeit grace sung by a corpse. Buster's parting hope, voiced as he rises, is for a place up ahead where poker is played fair. His heaven is not the abolition of chance but chance without the fix: a toss no sovereign has rigged. In 'Near Algodones', a bank robber escapes one hanging when Comanches kill his executioners, only to be hanged again for a theft of cattle he did not commit; on the second scaffold,

beside a weeping man, he asks whether it is his first time. Kierkegaard's repetition is denied him; Hammett's beam, as the next chapter recalls, falls twice.

'Meal Ticket' is the anthology's essay on art and money. An impresario tours frontier towns with a young orator who has neither arms nor legs and who recites, nightly, Shelley's 'Ozymandias', the story of Cain and Abel from Genesis, passages of Shakespeare, and the Gettysburg Address. The receipts dwindle. The impresario buys a chicken that appears to perform arithmetic by pecking at numbered cards, and on the road thereafter he stops on a bridge, drops a stone into the river to gauge its depth, and drives on with the chicken and without the orator; the film implies, without showing, that he has thrown the orator from the bridge. Art has been replaced by calculation, the orator by a Mentaculus with feathers. The choice of 'Ozymandias' is exact. Shelley's sonnet (1818) describes the 'shattered visage' of a king half sunk in the desert sand, beneath an inscription commanding the mighty to look on his works and despair: the sovereign's face eroded, the obverse of every coin worn smooth.

'All Gold Canyon', adapted from Jack London's story (1905), follows an old prospector into an Edenic valley, where he pans for gold and addresses the vein he seeks as 'Mister Pocket', gold personified as a hidden person to be courted. He is shot in the back by a young man who has waited for him to find the pocket, survives, kills his assailant, and leaves; the canyon returns to stillness, and an owl resumes her nest. Gold, the metal of the coin before it is struck, is here personified, desired, and bloodied, and nature, indifferent, closes over the scene. 'The Gal Who Got Rattled', adapted from Stewart Edward White, follows a young woman on a wagon train bound for Oregon. Her brother dies of cholera, a decent young wagon master proposes, and during a Comanche attack, believing her protector killed, she uses on herself the pistol he had given her against capture, though he has in fact survived. The tale is the anthology's monadology: a death produced by a misreading of the battle, the woman's perception and the world failing, for want of harmony, to correspond.

'The Mortal Remains' closes the book. In a stagecoach at dusk, five passengers, among them a trapper, a pious matron, a Frenchman, and two bounty hunters, an Englishman and an Irishman, who describe themselves as reapers, converse about human nature and death while a corpse rides on the roof. The Englishman explains that the reapers like to watch a man's face at the moment of passage, as he tries to make sense of it. Levinas located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose expression issues the command not to kill; the reapers watch the face as spectacle at the instant the command is overridden. The coach arrives by night at a hotel in Fort Morgan; the reapers carry the corpse upstairs; the others enter hesitantly; the door closes. The anthology ends where *Barton Fink*'s hotel began: in a lodging for a day or a lifetime. The Western, which a generation of critics read through the injunction in John Ford's *The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance* (1962) to print the legend, here prints the ledger of its dead, and the book closes.

Across the West of *True Grit* and *Buster Scruggs* runs one image that unites the coin's operations more starkly than any other: the wanted poster, a face printed beside a price. The bounty is the Western's numismatic theology, the face of the other minted into a sum. The bounty hunters of 'The Mortal Remains', the marshal paid by the prisoner, the reward the frontier offers for a man dead or alive, form the obverse of the Western's mythology, and the edge, when it appears, is the act that refuses to price a face: Rooster's ride.

7.3

The Comedies of the Con

The comic form of numismatic theology is the con, and the confidence man is its lay priest. Herman Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857), set aboard a Mississippi steamboat on April Fools' Day, presents a shape-shifting figure who solicits the passengers' trust in a series of disguises and leaves the reader unable to say whether he is a devil, a charlatan, or a Christ testing charity. The book's subject is confidence itself, the fiduciary bond on which money, religion, and society alike depend. Mark Twain's 'The Man That Corrupted Hadleyburg' (1899) ruins a town proud of its honesty with a sack that purports to contain gold coins and contains gilded lead discs, and his 'The £1,000,000 Bank-Note' (1893) imagines a penniless man who lives on credit on the strength of a note too large for anyone to change: fiat value in its purest form. Charles Baudelaire's prose poem 'La Fausse Monnaie' (1869), in which a man gives a beggar a counterfeit coin while appearing generous, became in Derrida's *Donner le temps* (1991) the occasion of a meditation on whether a counterfeit can be a gift, and on literature as a counterfeit money that circulates as if it were real.

The Coen corpus is a sustained comedy of the con. *Raising Arizona* builds a counterfeit family: a stolen child raised by a thief and a policewoman, whose love for him is the only uncounterfeited thing in a film of false identities. *Intolerable Cruelty* (2003) builds counterfeit marriages. Its hero, the divorce lawyer Miles Massey, is the inventor of an unbreakable prenuptial agreement; its heroine, Marylin Rexroth, a serial divorcée, marries a Texas oil baron who, at the wedding, tears up the agreement and eats it, and who is later revealed to be a soap-opera actor hired for the con. The film is a late and cynical entry in the genre Stanley Cavell named the comedy of remarriage (*Pursuits of Happiness*, 1981), in which a couple separate and are reunited through a conversation that educates each in acknowledgment of the other. Cavell's comedies replace knowledge, which the sceptic despairs of, with acknowledgment, which the lover offers. *Intolerable Cruelty* stages the replacement as a sacramental joke. The prophet Ezekiel is commanded to eat a scroll, which is sweet as honey in his mouth (Ezekiel 3:1–3), and the seer of Revelation eats a little book that is sweet in the mouth and bitter in the belly (Revelation 10:9–10). A counterfeit groom eats the contract: the performative that would have fixed the outcome is consumed by a false flesh, the incarnation run backward, and the marriage that follows is left to the edge. The parody reaches into Cavell's

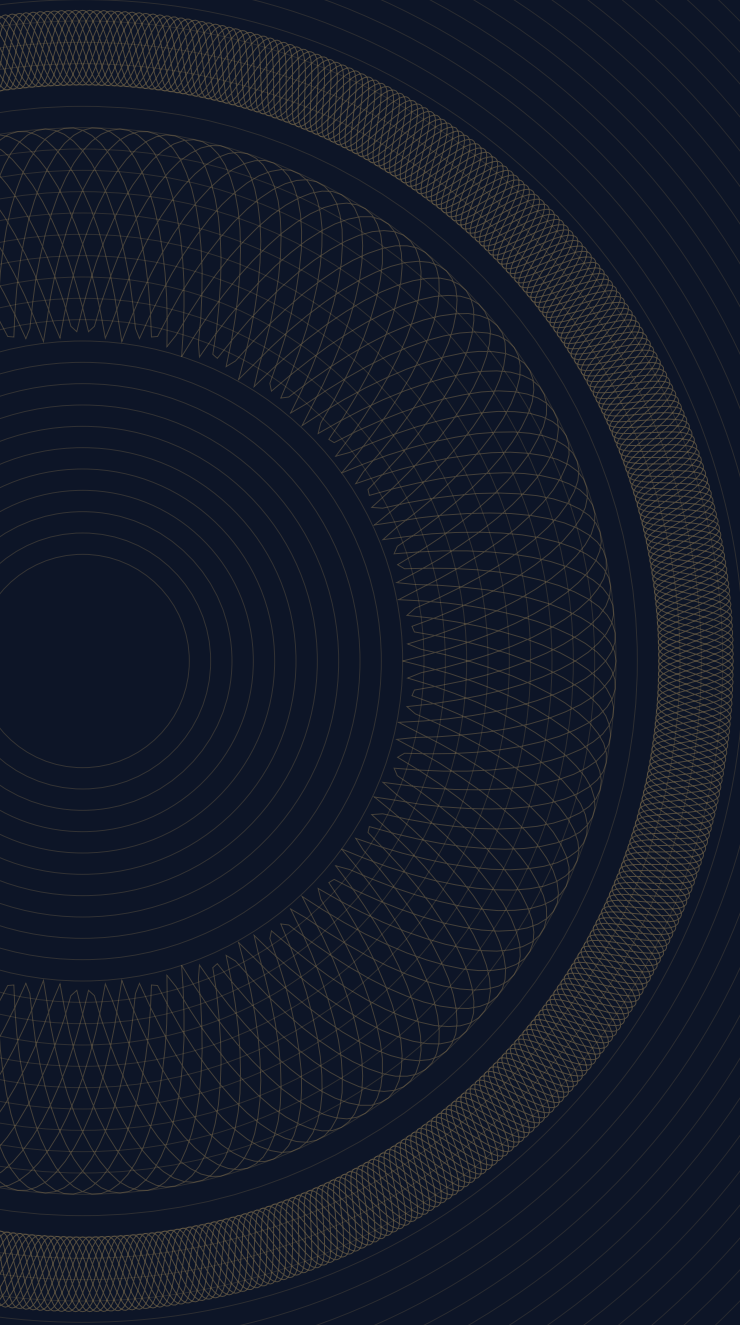
canon itself: Howard D. Doyle, who eats the agreement with barbecue sauce, recalls the Oklahoma oilman whom Ralph Bellamy plays as the decent, doomed rival in Leo McCarey's 1937 comedy of remarriage with Irene Dunne and Cary Grant, one of the films at the centre of Cavell's book. The Coens counterfeit the genre's own rival suitor, and the counterfeit outbids the original by eating the contract the original would have honoured. The film's hired killer, an asthmatic who reaches for his inhaler and takes up his pistol instead, executes on its executor Henri Bergson's formula for the comic, the mechanical encrusted on the living (*Le Rire*, 1900).

The Ladykillers (2004), a remake of the Ealing comedy of 1955, transposes its gang of thieves to the Mississippi, where Professor G. H. Dorr, a florid admirer of Poe, rents a room from a devout Black widow, Marva Munson, in order to tunnel into the vault of a riverboat casino under cover of a Renaissance music ensemble that never plays. The gang dies one by one, by accident and by one another's hands, each body dropped from a bridge onto a garbage scow bound for an island landfill, and Mrs. Munson, who has witnessed none of it, is left with the money. She gives it to Bob Jones University. Providence in *The Ladykillers* is slapstick, a chain of accidents whose sum is the return of a casino's money to a religious institution: rendered, in the end, unto God. Above the widow's mantel hangs the portrait of her late husband, Othar, whose painted expression changes in response to events. It is the only face in the corpus that answers, and it is a picture.

Hail, Caesar!, finally, is a cathedral of cons, and its most audacious is legal and theological at once. The swimming star DeeAnna Moran, unmarried and pregnant, is to give birth in secret, place the child with an agency, and then adopt it, so that the child may be hers without having been conceived out of wedlock, the studio supplying a man of good character to stand in the place of the legal father. The scheme parodies adoption as a legal fiction and, through it, the theological doctrine by which the believer becomes a child of God not by nature but by grace, receiving 'the adoption of sons' (Galatians 4:5). The studio fabricates a holy family.

The con artist in each of these films stands in a relation to the audience that the Coens share. They announce their cons. *Fargo* swears it is true and then denies it. Their editor, Roderick Jaynes, twice nominated for the Academy Award, does not exist: the name is a pseudonym under which the brothers edit their own films, furnished with an elderly English persona. Søren Kierkegaard published his major works under pseudonyms, Johannes de Silentio, Johannes Climacus, Constantin Constantius, and explained the practice as indirect communication: the author withdraws so that the reader must appropriate the truth for himself rather than receive it on authority (*Afsluttende uvidenskabelig Efterskrift*, 1846; *Synspunktet for min Forfatter-Virksomhed*, written 1848). Roderick Jaynes is the Coens' Johannes Climacus, and their refusal to explain their films is Kierkegaardian method. The

con, announced, becomes a gift: a counterfeit coin offered with the declaration that it is counterfeit, so that the recipient must decide for himself what it is worth.





PART THREE

Constellations

CHAPTER EIGHT.

Constellations



I look, you look, he looks; we look, ye look, they look.
— Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick* (1851), chapter 99

CHAPTER EIGHT

Constellations

Speculative, Mythological, and Philosophical Fictions of the Coin

8.1

The Numismatic Lineage

The coin has a literary genealogy in the Americas, and the Coens stand at its present end. Its founding text is the ninety-ninth chapter of *Moby-Dick*, 'The Doubloon'. Ahab has nailed an Ecuadorian gold doubloon to the mainmast as the reward for the first man to raise the white whale, and in this chapter the crew pass before it one by one and read its iconography: three Andean summits, one bearing a flame, one a tower, one a crowing cock, beneath an arching segment of the zodiac. Ahab sees in the coin his own egotism; Starbuck, a Trinitarian consolation darkened by doubt; Stubb, an almanac of the sun's progress through a human life; Flask, sixteen dollars, which at two cents a cigar comes to nine hundred and sixty cigars; the old Manxman, an omen; Queequeg compares its markings with his tattoos; and Pip, the cabin boy driven mad by his abandonment at sea, conjugates a verb: I look, you

look, he looks; we look, ye look, they look. Ahab himself supplies the chapter's thesis: 'this round gold is but the image of the rounder globe, which, like a magician's glass, to each and every man in turn but mirrors back his own mysterious self.' Melville's doubloon is the coin as hermeneutic mirror, and Pip's conjugation is one of the most devastating sentences in the history of American interpretation, for it reduces every reading to the grammar of looking.

Dashiell Hammett's *The Maltese Falcon* (1930) contains a parable its hero tells for no apparent reason. A Tacoma real-estate man named Flitcraft, passing a building under construction, is nearly killed by a falling beam. The near miss shows him that life is governed not by order but by falling beams, and he walks away that day from his family and his business. Years later Sam Spade finds him in Spokane, remarried to a woman much like his first wife and living a life much like his first life: he had adjusted himself to beams falling, and when no more of them fell, he adjusted himself to their not falling. The Flitcraft parable is the American template of the Coen protagonist's trajectory. Ed Crane, Llewyn Davis, and Larry Gopnik each glimpse the beam, and each in his way returns to the life the beam interrupted. Jorge Luis Borges's 'El Zahir' (1949) concerns a twenty-centavo coin that its narrator receives as change at a bar after a wake, and which, once seen, cannot be forgotten. The coin fills his mind; he spends it deliberately and cannot spend it from thought; he reflects that money is abstract, that it is future time, a repertory of possible futures; he anticipates that he will soon perceive nothing but the coin, and wonders whether God may be found behind it. And in Cormac McCarthy's novel (2005) and the Coens' film (2007), a coin with a twenty-two-year history passes across a counter and decides a life. Melville's coin mirrors; Hammett's beam falls; Borges's coin obsesses; McCarthy's and the Coens' decides. The lineage traces the coin's passage from object of interpretation to agent of fate.

8.2

The Lottery-World

Borges's 'La lotería en Babilonia' (1941) describes a society in which a lottery, administered by a secret Company, has been extended until it governs every aspect of life: rewards and punishments, offices and deaths, the very interpretation of events. The Company's operations are invisible. Some hold that it is eternal, others that it does not exist, others that its existence or non-existence is a matter of indifference, since Babylon is nothing but an infinite game of chance. The Coen cosmos is Babylon, and Chigurh is one of the Company's agents, or believes he is. Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962) imagines an America partitioned by the victorious Axis powers in which several characters consult the I Ching, the Chinese oracle consulted by casting yarrow stalks or coins, and Dick reported that he consulted it himself in plotting the novel. At the novel's end the oracle discloses that the world in which it is consulted is false and that Germany and Japan in fact lost the war: Dick's

oracle opens onto a truer world behind the fiction. The Coen coin opens onto nothing behind it. It is the same gesture with the metaphysics removed.

Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead* (1966) opens with its heroes spinning coins that have come down heads ninety-two consecutive times, and with Guildenstern's anxious speculation on the law of averages and the possibility that they are under some supernatural control. The explanation, of course, is that they are characters in *Hamlet*, and their fate is written. Stoppard's minor characters, who wander into a plot not their own and die in it without understanding why, are the Coen protagonists' nearest theatrical kin: the Dude, a stoner mistaken for a millionaire; Llewyn, a bit player in the history of folk music; Ed Crane, a man in someone else's noir. Kurt Vonnegut's *The Sirens of Titan* (1959) founds the Church of God the Utterly Indifferent and reveals that the whole of human history has been manipulated by distant beings in order to deliver a small replacement part to a stranded robot messenger: a MacGuffin on the scale of civilisation. And Douglas Adams's *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* (1979) supplied the definitive comic image of validity without significance: an answer, forty-two, computed correctly over seven and a half million years, to a question no one can state.

8.3

The Anti-Detective

William Spanos named, in 'The Detective and the Boundary' (1972), a postmodern form that frustrates the detective story's promise of a solution and so exposes the metaphysics of order on which the classical detective depends. Borges supplied its masterpiece in 'La muerte y la brújula' (1942), in which the detective Erik Lönnrot decodes a series of murders as a cabbalistic pattern, follows the pattern to its predicted point, and finds there his enemy, who constructed the pattern as a trap: the detective's hermeneutic success is his death. Stanisław Lem pressed the form into science. In *Śledztwo* (*The Investigation*, 1959), Scotland Yard confronts corpses that move in English mortuaries, and the only explanation offered is statistical, a pattern in the distribution of events with no agent behind it. In *Katar* (*The Chain of Chance*, 1976), an investigator reconstructs a series of deaths around Naples and finds that no one caused them; each resulted from an improbable concatenation of ordinary factors. In *Głos Pana* (*His Master's Voice*, 1968), scientists receive a signal from space that they can neither fully decode nor dismiss, and in *Solaris* (1961) a library of interpretations accumulates around an alien ocean that may or may not be communicating. Lem's universe is the nearest literary analogue to the Coens': a world in which patterns are real, causes are distributed, and the sign from beyond, like the letters on the goy's teeth, demands an interpretation that never arrives.

Thomas Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) leaves its heroine, Oedipa Maas, unable to decide whether the Tristero, a secret postal system whose emblem is a muted post horn, is

a conspiracy, a hoax, or a hallucination; Pynchon's *Inherent Vice* (2009), whose marijuana-soaked detective Doc Sportello navigates Los Angeles at the turn of the 1970s, is *The Big Lebowski*'s literary cousin. Don DeLillo's *White Noise* (1985), in which an airborne toxic event disrupts a professor's suburban life, contains the sentence that describes the Coen plot better than any critic has: 'All plots tend to move deathward.' The anti-detective tradition shares with the Coens the frustration of solution. What it rarely shares is their moral centre. Marge solves the case, and the solution does not restore order; it merely ends the killing.

8.4

Theodicy Fictions

Voltaire's *Candide* (1759), written in the aftermath of the Lisbon earthquake against the Leibnizian claim that this is the best of all possible worlds, established the comic anti-theodicy as a genre; its hero's final resolution, that we must cultivate our garden, is a minimal ethics of the edge. Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov, refusing a harmony purchased with the tears of a tortured child, respectfully returns his ticket to God. Ursula K. Le Guin's 'The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas' (1973) imagines a city whose happiness depends on the misery of one child, and the few who, learning of it, leave. Flannery O'Connor's 'A Good Man Is Hard to Find' (1953) produces, in the escaped convict called the Misfit, Chigurh's closest literary ancestor: a philosophical killer who explains, before shooting a grandmother, that Jesus threw everything off balance, and who says of her afterward, in substance, that she would have been a good woman had there been somebody there to shoot her every minute of her life. O'Connor described her fiction as concerned with the action of grace in territory held largely by the devil, and the grandmother's moment of grace, her recognition of the Misfit as one of her own children, is the edge reached at gunpoint. Cormac McCarthy's Judge Holden in *Blood Meridian* (1985), for whom war is god, is Chigurh's other ancestor, and McCarthy's *The Sunset Limited* (2006), a dialogue between a believer and the professor he has just stopped from taking his own life, stages the theodicy debate that the Coens decline to stage. Mark Twain's posthumously assembled *The Mysterious Stranger* (1916) ends with its Satan revealing that nothing exists, that all is a dream. The Coen corpus contains several dreams of revelation, H.I.'s, Larry's, Bell's, and its endings repeatedly turn on waking.

8.5

Holy Fools and Schlemiels

The Coen protagonist belongs to the long European and Jewish lineage of the holy fool. Cervantes's knight, Wagner's Parsifal, Singer's Gimpel, Sholem Aleichem's Tevye, and Melville's Bartleby have appeared in earlier chapters; Samuel Beckett's Vladimir and Estragon (*En attendant Godot*, 1952), waiting beside a single tree for a figure who does

not come, complete the company. Llewyn Davis waits for a career; Larry Gopnik waits for Marshak; the Dude waits for nothing and is therefore the only one not waiting. Beckett's two acts, in which the second repeats the first with slight variation, are the template of *Inside Llewyn Davis*, and his tramps' inability to leave, resolving to go and not moving, is the template of every Coen character who resolves to escape and stays.

8.6

Myth

Homer's *Odyssey*, Joyce's *Ulysses* (1922), Kazantzakis's *Odysseia* (1938), and C. P. Cavafy's 'Ithaka' (1911), which counsels the traveller to pray that the road be long and to understand on arrival that Ithaka gave the journey and has nothing more to give, form the lineage of *O Brother* and *Inside Llewyn Davis*. The Coens' contribution is to split the homecoming between a hero who returns to a wife demanding the original ring and a hero who never leaves the loop. The *Epic of Gilgamesh*, whose hero mourns his dead companion Enkidu and loses to a serpent the plant that would have restored his youth, is the ancient form of Llewyn's grief for Mike. The Grail cycle, through Weston and Eliot, organises *The Big Lebowski*; Frazer's King of the Wood organises *Miller's Crossing*. Ovid's *Metamorphoses* lends *O Brother* the apparent transformation of Pete into a toad, which the film declines to confirm, and Kafka's 'Die Verwandlung' (1915) lends it the horror of a metamorphosis met with bureaucratic calm. Dante's *Inferno* is everywhere in *Barton Fink*, from the lift that descends through the Hotel Earle to the burning corridor, and its frozen lowest circle is the destination of Llewyn's winter road. Joseph Campbell's monomyth, finally, is the template the Coens most consistently break, since their heroes depart and are tried and return, if at all, empty-handed.

8.7

Hollywood Apocalypses and Counterfeit Worlds

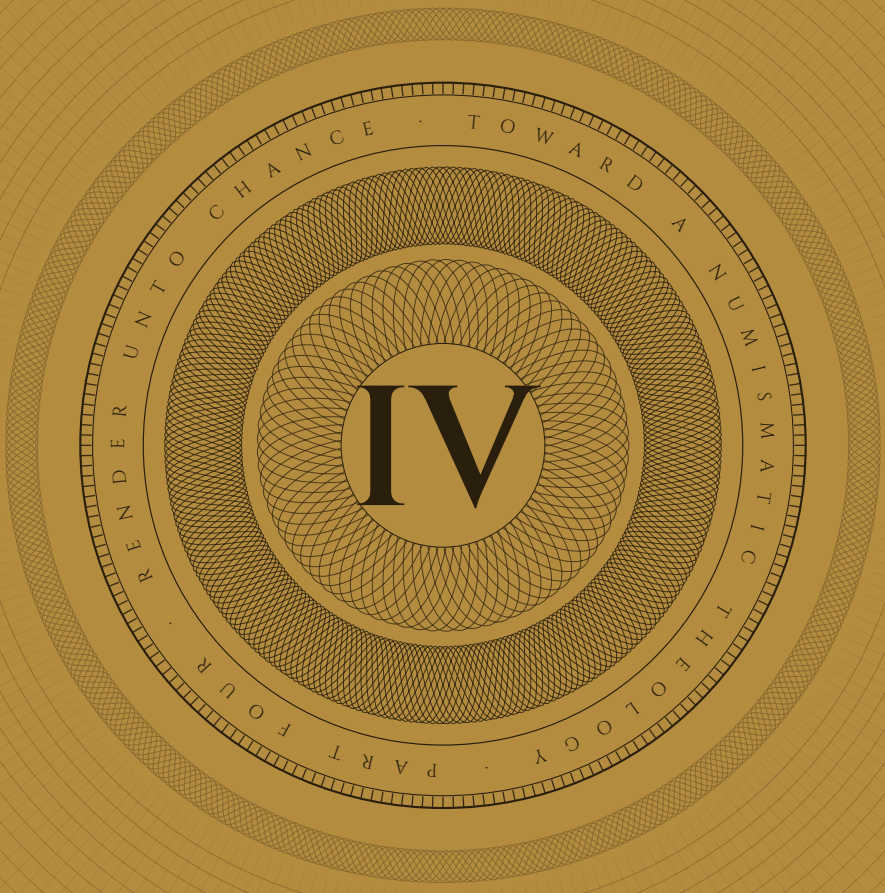
Nathanael West's *The Day of the Locust* (1939) ends with a riot at a Hollywood premiere and its painter-hero, Tod Hackett, imagining his canvas 'The Burning of Los Angeles'; *Barton Fink*'s burning hotel is West's painting realised. F. Scott Fitzgerald's unfinished *The Last Tycoon* (1941) supplied, in Monroe Stahr, a portrait of the studio head as sovereign that the Coens divide between Lipnick's tyranny and Mannix's sanctity. Borges's 'El milagro secreto' (1943) grants Jaromir Hladík, a Jewish playwright in Nazi-occupied Prague facing a firing squad, a year of time frozen between the order to fire and the volley, in which he completes in his mind the verse drama he will never write down. *Barton Fink*, set in 1941, inverts the miracle: its Jewish playwright writes the best work of his life in a single feverish night and is condemned to have nothing he writes ever produced. Borges's 'Tlön, Uqbar,

Orbis Tertius' anticipates *Fargo*'s fiction that colonises the real; his 'Pierre Menard, autor del Quijote' (1939), whose hero composes, word for word, chapters identical to Cervantes's and thereby produces a different and richer work, supplies Chapter Nine's theory of Coen pastiche. And André Gide's *Les Faux-monnayeurs* (1925), a novel about counterfeit coins in which a novelist named Édouard is writing a novel called *The Counterfeiters*, is the modernist template of the Coen mise en abyme: the film about a studio making a film, the narrator writing his confession for a magazine, the anthology that is a book.

8.8

The Coens' Specificity

The comparison clarifies what is the Coens' own. They share with speculative fiction an interest in alternative orders of causality, with mythic narrative the template of the quest, with the anti-detective tradition the frustration of solution, and with theodicy fiction the refusal to justify. Three features, in combination, distinguish them. The first is realism. Their worlds obey the ordinary laws of physics and the extraordinary laws of genre, and their departures from realism are rare, local, and unexplained, which makes them, in Meillassoux's terms, extro-science fiction in realist dress. The second is the coin. Where Borges's Zahir leads toward God and Dick's oracle toward a truer world, the Coen coin leads nowhere beyond itself, and its meaning is exhausted by its operations. The third is the edge. Lem's investigators, Pynchon's Oedipa, and Beckett's tramps are left suspended in the undecidable; the Coens consistently locate, in a minority of figures, a form of life that inhabits the undecidable without anguish, and this form of life is not a mood but an ethics. Chapter Nine names it.



PART FOUR

Render unto Chance

CHAPTER NINE

Render unto Chance



Dixitque Deus: Fiat lux. Et facta est lux.

— Genesis 1:3 (Vulgate)

CHAPTER NINE

Render unto Chance

Toward a Numismatic Theology

9.1

The Minting of the Face

Numismatic theology begins with a substitution. In the Hebrew Bible the face (*panim*) is the medium of relation with God: the LORD speaks to Moses face to face, as a man speaks to his friend (Exodus 33:11); the priestly blessing asks that he make his face shine upon Israel (Numbers 6:25); the curse is that he will hide it (Deuteronomy 31:18). In the Gospels the image (*eikon*) on the coin is Caesar's, while the human creature bears the image of God (Genesis 1:27), which is why what is God's must be rendered to him: the coin bears Caesar's face, the person bears God's. In the twentieth century Emmanuel Levinas made the face of the other the origin of ethics. The face, in its nakedness and exposure, expresses a command, 'thou shalt not kill', before it expresses anything else (*Totalité et infini*, 1961). Numismatic theology names the condition in which all three faces have been minted. The

divine face is hidden; the face of the other is appraised rather than encountered; and the only face reliably in circulation is the sovereign effigy on a coin, which can be valued, tossed, and spent.

The Coen corpus is a sustained study of faces under appraisal. The close-ups of Jerry Lundegaard's stricken smile, of Ed Crane's smoke-veiled stare, of Larry Gopnik's bewildered patience, of the filling-station proprietor's dawning terror, are portraits of faces being priced. The star system of *Hail, Caesar!* manufactures faces as currency; the wanted posters of the Western print faces beside sums; Ozymandias's shattered visage lies in the sand. And Chigurh, the corpus's purest agent of the coin, never needs to look at a face at all, since the coin's face looks for him. The ethical moment, in the rare instances the films allow it, is the moment in which a face refuses to be minted: Carla Jean, insisting that Chigurh own what he is about to do; Marge, turning in the patrol car to speak to the silent killer in the back seat as though he could hear her.

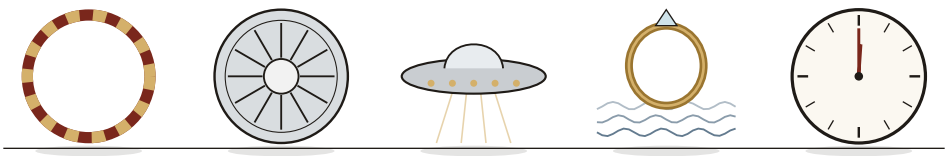
9.2

Heads, Tails, Edge: The Peircean Topology

The coin's three surfaces correspond, as Chapter Three proposed, to Peirce's three modes of evolution. The obverse is anancastic: the domain of necessity, sovereignty, and the Fix, in which outcomes are predetermined by force, as Caspar fixes fights and Mussburger fixes stock, as Lipnick fixes contracts and Macbeth fixes the future. The reverse is tychastic: the domain of chance, misreading, and the Toss, in which windowless monads collide without harmony, as in *Blood Simple*, *Fargo*, *Burn After Reading*, and the death on the wagon train. The edge is agapastic: the domain of love, in Peirce's sense of a growth drawn by sympathy toward the ends of others, and of the Abiding, in which a value declines to be decided.

Four clarifications follow. First, the edge is not a synthesis. Hegel's *Aufhebung* cancels and preserves its terms in a higher unity; the edge cancels nothing, preserves nothing, and rises to no higher unity. It is a third outcome, not a third term. Second, the edge is unstable. A coin on its rim is in unstable equilibrium, and the slightest disturbance topples it; the films' edge-figures hold their position only for a time. Marge goes back to a world of wood chippers, the Dude to a world of nihilists, and Bell wakes. Third, the edge rolls. A coin on its rim, set in motion, describes a circle, and the corpus's most persistent visual motif is the rolling or suspended disc: the hula hoop that rolls through the streets to the feet of a boy, the hubcap that rolls toward Ed Crane, the flying saucer that hovers over a prison yard, the ring in the drowned house, the clock face stopped by an old man's hand. The edge in motion is a wheel that is not Fortune's, a circle that turns without falling.

Fourth, the edge is not where the films resolve. Aristotle's *Poetics* (chapter 15) objected to resolving a plot by the machine, the god lowered onto the stage, and asked that recognition (*anagnorisis*) arise from the action itself. The Coens' endings repeatedly lower something



THE HOOP
The Hudsucker Proxy

THE HUBCAP
The Man Who Wasn't There

THE SAUCER
The Man Who Wasn't There

THE RING
O Brother, Where Art Thou?

THE CLOCK
The Hudsucker Proxy

a circle that turns without falling

FIG. 10 The edge rolls. The corpus's rolling and suspended discs, each a coin that has fallen to neither face: the hoop, the hubcap, the saucer, the ring in the drowned house, the clock stopped by an old man's hand.

from the sky, a flood, a tornado, an angel, a saucer, and repeatedly withhold the recognition it should bring. Their figure is not the *deus ex machina* but the machine without the god: the apparatus of resolution descends and resolves nothing. The edge-figures are found instead in the films' last conversations: Marge in bed with Norm, Bell at his kitchen table, Mattie at a grave.

9.3

Fiat: Validity without Significance

Scholem's formula for Kafka's world, validity without significance, describes the Coen sign, and the economic name for such a sign is fiat. Fiat money is currency whose value derives from the decree of its issuer rather than from any commodity backing it; *fiat* is also the verb of the Vulgate's first creative act, *fiat lux*, let there be light. Creation by decree and value by decree share a word, and the Coen corpus was produced entirely within the historical period in which the second became universal. On 15 August 1971 the United States suspended the convertibility of the dollar into gold, precipitating the end of the Bretton Woods system; from that date the world's reserve currency has been backed by nothing but the credit of its issuer. The Coen corpus, from 1984 to 2018, is the cinema of the fiat era. Its films set before 1971 are haunted by gold: the two California gold pieces of *True Grit*, the prospector's 'Mister Pocket', the imaginary hoard of *O Brother* in a country whose private gold had been recalled. Its films set after 1971 turn on unbacked value: the illegible vehicle numbers of Jerry Lundegaard's loans, the empty briefcase of *The Big Lebowski*, the worthless disc of *Burn After Reading*, released in the week the credit system broke.

The corpus's central coin makes the point with numismatic exactness. Chigurh's coin is a quarter struck in 1958, and a quarter of that date belongs to the last generation of American coinage with intrinsic value: until the Coinage Act of 1965, dimes, quarters, and half-dollars were ninety per cent silver, after which they were struck in base-metal alloys, and the silver coins already in circulation were hoarded out of it, as Gresham's law predicts, bad money driving out good. *No Country for Old Men* is set in 1980, the year in which the Hunt brothers' attempt to corner the silver market collapsed on 'Silver Thursday', 27 March, after driving silver to prices that made the metal in such a quarter worth many times its face. The Introduction described the coin as bearing the effigy of a republic that guarantees its worth; in this case the guarantee understates it. Chigurh's warning that the coin, pocketed, would mingle with the others and become merely a coin is false in a way he does not register. His lot is a piece of commodity money, a relic of backed value that has survived twenty-two years of Gresham's law to be spent as chance in the fiat era: the one object on the counter whose worth is not decreed. And the man whose life it decides has, Chigurh learns, married into the filling station, so that the livelihood he stakes came to him by alliance rather than by wage. The toss converts a life received as a gift into a wager, which is what aleatory sovereignty always does.

A pattern of anachronism confirms that the Coen sign can circulate before its backing exists. *A Serious Man*, set in 1967, bills Larry for Santana's *Abraxas*, released in 1970. *Hail, Caesar!*, set in 1951, shows Mannix a photograph of a hydrogen bomb test that would not take place until the following year, and not at Bikini. *Inside Llewyn Davis*, set in 1961, hangs a poster for *The Incredible Journey* (1963) in a cinema lobby and ends with Dylan's 'Farewell', a song of 1963. *O Brother, Where Art Thou?*, set in 1937, puts 'You Are My Sunshine' on a governor's campaign trail, though it was not recorded until 1940, an anachronism the brothers acknowledged. These are not lapses of research. They are fiat signs in the precise sense: issued in advance of the history that would back them, and honoured by the films as though the backing were already in the vault.

Fiat validity is the condition of every Coen sign. *Fargo*'s title card is a fiat: a declaration of truth that creates by decree the status it claims, backed by nothing, honoured by the audience on credit, and repudiated in the credits. The 'DLR' in the trooper's ticket book is valid without significance until Marge reads it as a type. The letters on the goy's teeth are valid and signify nothing. Baird Whitlock's speech is valid and lacks its key word. Chigurh's coin is legal tender whose fall decides a life and which, in a pocket, would be merely a coin. The fiat sign binds because it is decreed and means nothing because nothing backs it, and the films' characters live and die in the gap between the binding and the meaning.

9.4

Kenotic Pastiche

Fredric Jameson defined pastiche as blank parody: the imitation of a style without parody's ulterior motive, without the satiric impulse or the conviction that a norm exists against which the imitated style is abnormal; and he read the nostalgia film as the symptom of a culture that has lost its capacity to represent its own history. On this account the Coens' period genres would be the purest postmodern artefacts, surfaces of dead styles recombined without depth. The account mistakes the emptiness of the Coen form for blankness, and Borges's Pierre Menard supplies the correction. Menard composes fragments identical, word for word, with *Don Quixote*, and Borges's narrator demonstrates that the identical text, written in the twentieth century by a Frenchman, is a different and richer work, since every phrase now carries the weight of the three centuries that separate it from Cervantes. Menardian repetition is not blank. It is a re-inscription in which the form is identical and the meaning transformed by its new situation.

Coen pastiche is Menardian, and its specific mode is kenotic. The genre is emptied of its guarantee of meaning, its promise of resolution, its providential architecture; but the vessel is preserved, as the kenotic Christ keeps the form of a servant and the Lurianic world keeps the husks in which the sparks are lodged. The emptied form does not signify nothing. It becomes a site of attention. *True Grit* preserves the Western's ledger of retribution and empties it of the genre's satisfaction, so that the viewer attends to the cost of each payment. *Fargo* preserves the procedural's solution and empties it of restored order, so that the viewer attends to the fact that a solution merely ends the killing. *The Big Lebowski* preserves Chandler's labyrinth and empties it of its solution, so that the viewer attends to the man who abides in it. The brothers' remakes confirm the mode. Their *True Grit* declined to remake Henry Hathaway's film of 1969 and returned instead to Portis's novel, re-inscribing its sentences; their *Ladykillers* re-inscribed the Ealing plot in a churchgoing Mississippi river town. Kenotic pastiche is the aesthetic form of numismatic theology: genre as a coin whose backing has been withdrawn, still circulating, still binding, and for the first time available to be weighed.

9.5

The Purim-Shpil and Learned Not-Knowing

Chapter Two proposed that Coen comedy has the form of a Purim-shpil, and the proposal can now be stated as a thesis. Purim celebrates a deliverance achieved through a lottery, in a book from which God's name is absent, by means of reversals that no character arranges and that the tradition reads as the hidden hand of a hidden God. Its carnival commands inversion, masking, and drunkenness to the point at which one cannot tell the curse of the

villain from the blessing of the hero. The Coen films are Purim plays from which the deliverance has been subtracted, except at the edge. They preserve the lottery, the hiddenness, the reversals, the masks, and the drunkenness; they withhold, in most cases, the salvation the reversals once announced; and they preserve, as their epistemic telos, the Talmudic limit: *ad de-lo yada*, until one does not know.

The not-knowing is not ignorance. Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) argued that the highest knowledge of the infinite is a learned ignorance, a knowing that one does not know which is more than not knowing; the anonymous fourteenth-century *Cloud of Unknowing* counselled the contemplative to enter a cloud between himself and God and to love what he could not know. The Coen spectator is trained in learned not-knowing. The films teach us to read their signs, the plates, the teeth, the box, the coin, with the full apparatus of interpretation, and then to recognise that the apparatus has reached its limit; and the recognition, when the films succeed, is not despair but a festive release. 'Accept the mystery' is the counsel of a briber's father, and its source discredits it. It is also, in its ironic way, Rashi's counsel, and the film knows it. The Purim-shpil ends with the festive meal, and *A Serious Man* ends with a tornado. The edge between them is learned not-knowing.

9.6

Counterfeit Grace

In Baudelaire's 'La Fausse Monnaie', the narrator watches a friend give a beggar a coin and then learns that it was counterfeit. He imagines at first that the friend wished to see what such a coin might do in a poor man's life, bring him prosperity or bring him prison, before concluding that the friend had merely hoped to purchase charity cheaply. Derrida's reading in *Donner le temps* asks whether a gift that is not what it appears to be can be a gift at all, and proposes, among much else, that literature is itself a species of counterfeit money, a currency of fiction circulating as if it were real, whose power to give depends on our uncertainty about its truth. The Coen films are counterfeit coins, and they say so. *Fargo* swears and then disclaims; Roderick Jaynes edits and does not exist; the Stranger addresses us from a bowling-alley bar. The declaration of counterfeit status is the brothers' irony, and Kierkegaard's distinction between romantic and mastered irony determines its value. In *Om Begrebet Ironi* (1841), Kierkegaard criticised the romantic irony of Schlegel as an infinite absolute negativity that hovers over every content and commits to none; mastered irony, by contrast, is irony brought into the service of a life, a negativity that clears the ground for appropriation. The charge of condescension against the Coens assumes that their irony is romantic. This dissertation holds that it is mastered. The irony of *Fargo* does not hover above Marge. It clears the ground on which Marge stands.

Grace in the Coen world can therefore only be counterfeit grace: unbacked by any guarantee, unwarranted by any providential order, given by fiat. Loren Visser's first sentence in

the first Coen film, that nothing comes with a guarantee, names the condition of every gift in the corpus. A gift with a guarantee would be a contract. Rooster's ride, Marge's kindness, the Dude's abiding, Mattie's reburial, a boy's offer of his shirt to a bleeding stranger, are gifts precisely because nothing backs them. They are fiat grace, issued without reserve and honoured, if at all, on credit. The corpus does not say that grace exists. It says that, if it exists, this is the only form it could take in a world whose god is legal tender: a coin known to be counterfeit, offered anyway.

9.7

The Ethics of the Edge

Five figures occupy the edge, and their acts compose an ethics. The first is attention. Iris Murdoch, in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), described the moral life as a discipline of attention, a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality, and gave as its emblem the moment when, anxious and resentful, she looks out of a window and sees a kestrel hovering, and her brooding self vanishes. Marge Gunderson is the corpus's Murdochian saint. Her goodness is not heroism but attention: to the dead, to the evidence, to Mike Yanagita's grief and then to its falsity, to her husband's paintings of ducks. The film's last scene, in bed with Norm, is its moral climax. Norm's mallard has been chosen for the three-cent stamp, while a rival's teal has taken the twenty-nine-cent; he is disappointed; Marge tells him that people need the three-cent stamp whenever the postage goes up. The image has become currency in its smallest denomination, and Marge affirms the smallest denomination as indispensable. Grace in *Fargo* is small change. And the last words are a countdown to a child: two more months.

The detail is exact. American first-class postage rose from twenty-two to twenty-five cents in April 1988, the year after the film's setting, and from twenty-nine to thirty-two cents in January 1995, the year before its release. Each time the difference was three cents, and the three-cent stamp was the denomination that made old stamps good at the new rate. Norm's mallard is minted, in other words, as the currency of the gap that inflation opens between an old price and a new one: grace in *Fargo* is the small change that makes up the difference.

And Marge says nothing of her own day. The woman who has just solved a series of murders spends the film's last conversation on her husband's three-cent stamp, so that her own achievement never enters the exchange. Derrida's pure gift, which must not appear as a gift lest recognition repay it, has rarely been figured more exactly than in what Marge leaves unsaid.

The second figure is abiding: the Dude's uselessness, his preference not to, his taking it easy on behalf of all us sinners. The third is fidelity: Mattie Ross, one-armed and unmarried, moving Rooster's remains to her family plot and completing for the dead a homecoming the living could not complete. The fourth is refusal: Carla Jean declining to call the toss,

insisting that the coin has no say and that the choice is the killer's alone. Her refusal does not save her, but it denies the coin its sovereignty and restores to the face across the room the responsibility the coin was minted to absorb. The fifth is restraint: Moses jamming the clock, the katechon who holds back the fall long enough for a letter to arrive. Around these five gather lesser lights: Norm's stamp, Penny's ring, the cat that walks home, the boy who offers his shirt, H.I.'s Utah.

Stanley Cavell's concept of acknowledgment unites them. In 'Knowing and Acknowledging' (1969) and *The Claim of Reason* (1979), Cavell argued that scepticism about other minds is not refuted but answered, and answered not by knowledge but by acknowledgment, a response to the other that does not wait upon proof. The Coen world is a world of insurmountable scepticism: monads without windows, signs without significance, faces minted into coin. Its edge-figures do not overcome the scepticism. They acknowledge. Marge acknowledges Grimsrud, speaking to him as if he could hear; the Dude acknowledges Walter, whose madness he never cures and never abandons; Mattie acknowledges Rooster; Carla Jean acknowledges Chigurh by insisting that he is a man and not an instrument. Acknowledgment is Peirce's agapastic mode translated into the ethics of persons, and it is the only form of love the Coen corpus can depict without irony.

The edge is not salvation. It is a stay. It lasts while the coin balances and the clock is stopped and the dream continues, and the films end, almost always, with its passing. But the corpus insists that the edge is real, that it occurs with a frequency that is low but not zero, and that a human life can be oriented toward it. On the physics of coins, the frequency has been estimated at once in six thousand tosses. On the testimony of the films it is not much higher, and it is enough.

9.8

Bell's Dream: Fire in a Horn

No Country for Old Men takes its title from the first line of W. B. Yeats's 'Sailing to Byzantium' (1928), 'That is no country for old men', a poem whose speaker asks to be gathered into the artifice of eternity. The film ends with a dream. The retired Sheriff Bell, at his kitchen table, tells his wife two dreams about his father. In the second, they are riding at night through mountains in the cold; his father rides past him without speaking, carrying fire in a horn the way people used to, and Bell knows that his father is going on ahead to make a fire somewhere out in all that dark and cold, and that when Bell gets there his father will be there. Then, he says, he woke up. The dream, taken from McCarthy's novel, is the corpus's last image of the edge, and its biblical depth rewards attention. In Genesis 22, Abraham rises early and goes with his son to the mountain God has shown him; he takes 'the fire in his hand, and a knife', and Isaac asks: 'Behold the fire and the wood: but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?' (Genesis 22:6–7). Bell's dream is the Akedah inverted. A father goes ahead

into the mountains carrying fire, but there is no knife and no altar; the fire is carried not to consume the son but to warm him; and the son follows not to be bound but to be met. Kierkegaard's *Frygt og Bæven* (*Fear and Trembling*, 1843), written under the name Johannes de Silentio, made Abraham the knight of faith, who suspends the ethical for a relation to the absolute he cannot explain. Bell's father is a knight of another order, a knight of fire, whose faith consists in going ahead to make a place of warmth in a dark the son has not yet entered.

The horn deserves its own remark. In McCarthy's text it is a frontier vessel for carrying embers; in the corpus's Hebrew substrate, horn is the material of the shofar, the ram's horn whose blast recalls the ram caught in the thicket by its horns and offered in Isaac's place (Genesis 22:13). The fire in the horn is the substitute sacrifice transformed into hospitality. And fire is the one element that cannot be minted: it is what melts coins back into metal and returns the effigy to the ore. The last image of the Coens' most numismatic film is of something uncoinable, carried ahead in the dark by a father who does not speak. Bell's last words, that he woke up, mark the coin's fall from its edge. The dream was the edge. The waking is heads or tails.



FIRE IN A HORN

Sheriff Bell's second dream: his father rides on ahead through the mountains at night, carrying fire in a horn, to make a fire somewhere out in all that dark and cold. The Akedah inverted: the fire is carried not to consume the son but to warm him.



CONCLUSION

Call It

This dissertation has argued that the films of Joel and Ethan Coen compose a numismatic theology, and it has proposed, in the course of the argument, a set of concepts for reading them: the beetle-box MacGuffin, whose content cancels out of the exchange in which people die for it; monads without harmony, the epistemic condition of Coen noir; aleatory sovereignty, the sovereign decision that abdicates to a toss; the cinema as katechon, restraining an apocalypse photographed before it had happened; fiat validity, the binding force of signs backed by nothing; kenotic pastiche, the Menardian re-inscription of emptied genres as sites of attention; the Purim-shpil, the carnival of a hidden God in a world of lots, ordered toward learned not-knowing; and counterfeit grace, the only gift possible where the god is legal tender, practised at the edge by figures of attention, abiding, fidelity, refusal, and restraint. Together these concepts are offered as an alternative to the readings that have dominated the reception. The Coens are neither nihilists nor blank pasticheurs, neither genre anthologists nor theologians manqués. They are rigorous theologians of the coin.

A coda concerns the brothers themselves. After *The Ballad of Buster Scruggs*, Joel and Ethan Coen ceased, for a time, to make films together, and the work that followed divides the

coin along its faces with a neatness that invites interpretation, provided, once again, that the biographical is held lightly. Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth* is the obverse in its purest tragic form: a film about a crown, a prophecy, and a sovereignty that fixes the future and finds that it signifies nothing. Ethan Coen's films are the reverse in its carnival form. *Jerry Lee Lewis: Trouble in Mind* (2022) is a portrait of a performer raised in Pentecostal faith who long suspected that the music he played was the devil's. *Drive-Away Dolls* (2024) and *Honey Don't!* (2025), written with Tricia Cooke, are queer B-movies whose plots turn, respectively, on a car carrying contraband its drivers do not know about and on a megachurch run by a corrupt cult leader: counterfeit cargo and counterfeit sanctity. And *Drive-Away Dolls* opens, at last, the box. Among the contraband in its trunk, in a story set in 1999, are a hatbox containing a severed head and a briefcase of dildos cast in plaster from the erect penises of powerful men, one of them a family-values senator prepared to kill to recover his own. Thirty-three years after Barton Fink carried a box the size of a head into a painting, the head is in the box; and beside it, as though in answer to Freud, Lacan, and Goux, the general equivalent appears as a novelty item. Lacan's phallus, the signifier that no subject possesses, has become a set of plaster replicas that anyone can carry in a briefcase, and the senator's pursuit of his own replica restages, as farce, the corpus's whole pursuit of beetle-boxes. The beetle has been shown, and it is a joke.

If the obverse is Joel's and the reverse Ethan's, the edge was the collaboration: the improbable third outcome in which two brothers, for thirty-four years and eighteen films, declined to come down on either face. Whether the coin can be stood on its rim again is a question this study cannot answer, and its frame closes before any answer could arrive.

The corpus's central scene ends with a man told to call it. The proprietor calls heads, wins, and is sent on his way with a coin he has been warned not to pocket. Carla Jean declines to call, and does not walk away. Between the call and the refusal lies the whole of the Coens' ethics: the knowledge that every life is staked on a toss it did not choose, and the insistence that the toss does not have the last word. The coin is in the air. The films do not say how it will land, and they do not promise that it will land on its edge. They say that it can, that it sometimes has, and that a man in a bathrobe, a pregnant police chief, a girl who paid with an arm, a widow who would not call, and a cat who walked home were there when it did. Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must abide.

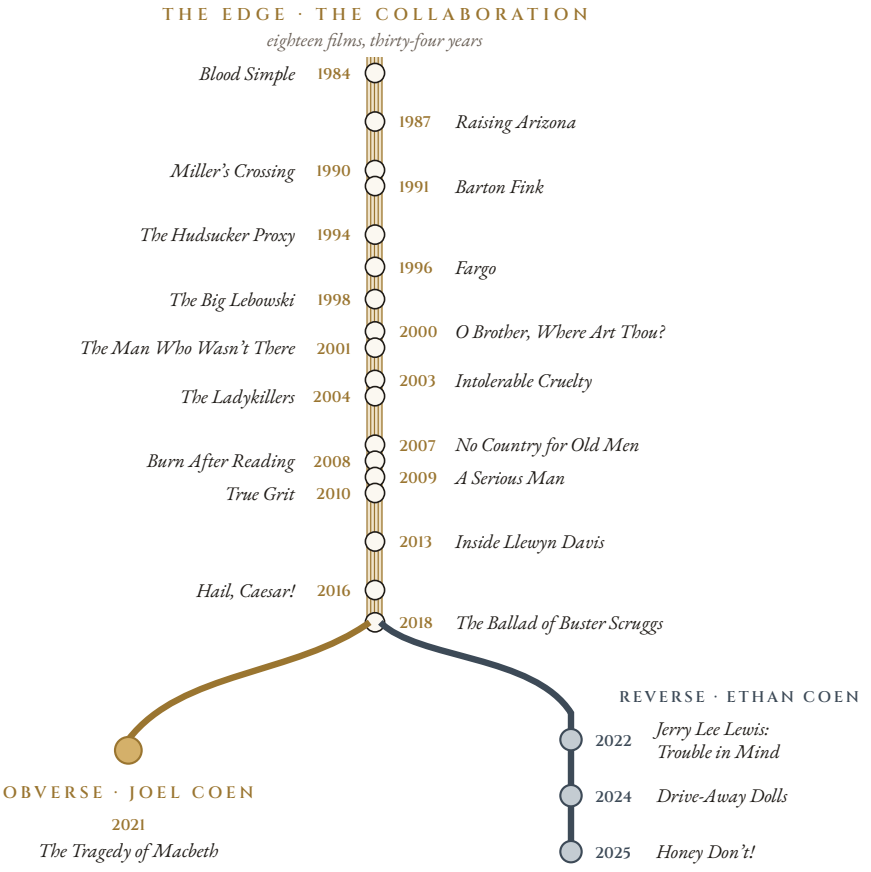
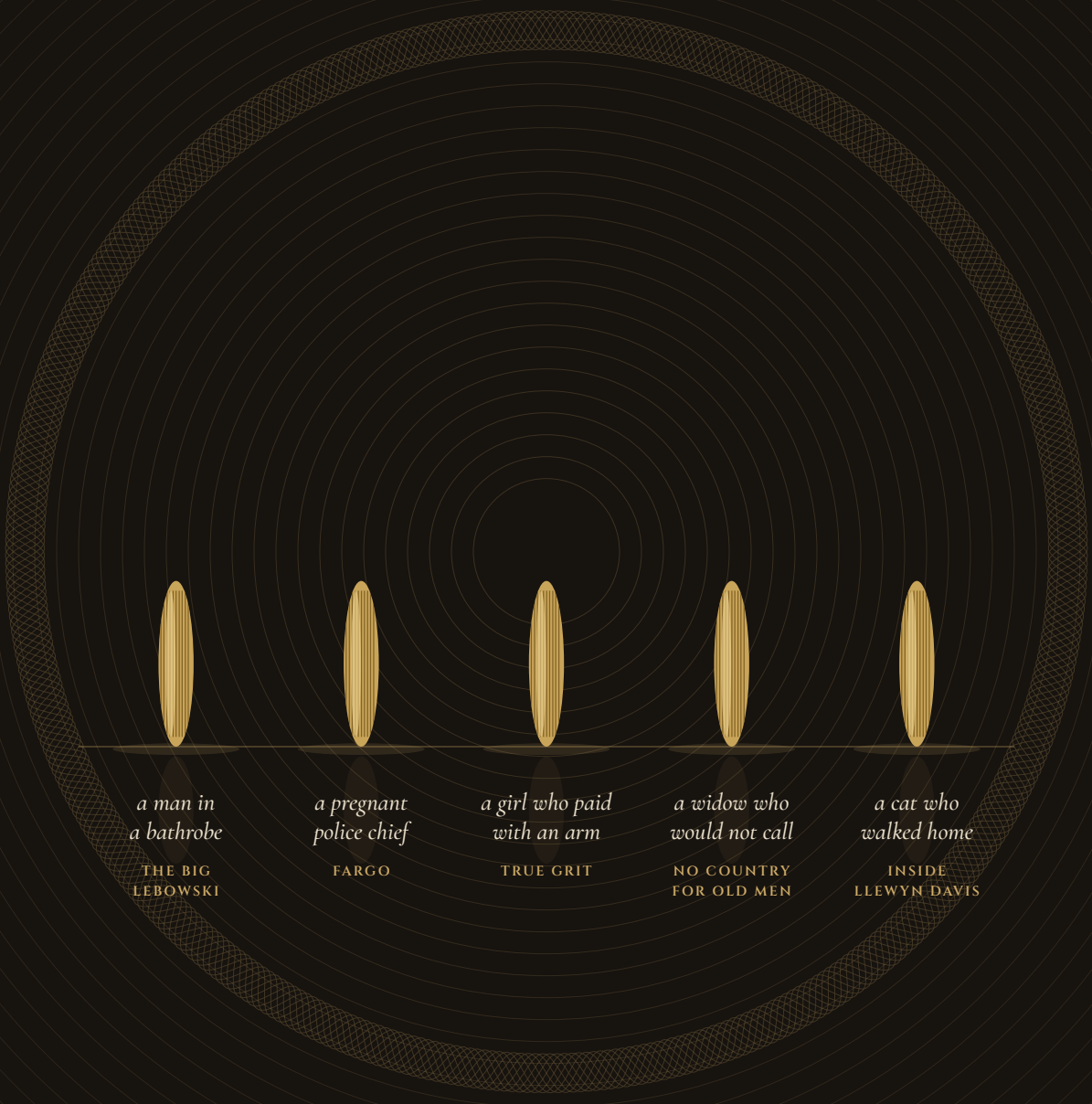


FIG. 11 The coin divides along its faces. Thirty-four years and eighteen films of collaboration, the edge, then the separate work after 2018: Joel Coen's obverse, Ethan Coen's reverse.



AT THE EDGE

In the Conclusion's words, those who were there when the coin landed on its edge.

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CORPUS FILMOGRAPHY

JOINT FEATURES

Written, directed, and produced by Joel and Ethan Coen (directing credit to Joel alone until 2004) and edited by them, often under the pseudonym Roderick Jaynes.

YEAR	TITLE	NOTE
1984	*Blood Simple*	Title from Hammett's *Red Harvest*
1987	*Raising Arizona*	
1990	*Miller's Crossing*	Draws on Hammett's *The Glass Key*
1991	*Barton Fink*	Palme d'Or, Cannes
1994	*The Hudsucker Proxy*	Co-written with Sam Raimi
1996	*Fargo*	Academy Awards for Original Screenplay and Best Actress
1998	*The Big Lebowski*	
2000	*O Brother, Where Art Thou?*	After Homer's *Odyssey*
2001	*The Man Who Wasn't There*	Best Director, Cannes (shared with David Lynch)
2003	*Intolerable Cruelty*	Screenplay with Robert Ramsey and Matthew Stone
2004	*The Ladykillers*	After William Rose's screenplay for the 1955 Ealing film
2007	*No Country for Old Men*	After Cormac McCarthy; Academy Award for Best Picture
2008	*Burn After Reading*	
2009	*A Serious Man*	
2010	*True Grit*	After Charles Portis
2013	*Inside Llewyn Davis*	Grand Prix, Cannes
2016	*Hail, Caesar!*	
2018	*The Ballad of Buster Scruggs*	Two tales after Jack London and Stewart Edward White; Best Screenplay, Venice

SHORT FILMS

'Tuileries', in *Paris, je t'aime* (2006); 'World Cinema', in *Chacun son cinéma* (2007).

SCREENPLAYS FOR OTHER DIRECTORS

Crimewave (Sam Raimi, 1985, with Raimi); *Gambit* (Michael Hoffman, 2012); *Unbroken* (Angelina Jolie, 2014, with Richard LaGravenese and William Nicholson); *Bridge of Spies* (Steven Spielberg, 2015, with Matt Charman); *Suburbicon* (George Clooney, 2017, with Clooney and Grant Heslov).

SEPARATE WORK AFTER 2018

Joel Coen: *The Tragedy of Macbeth* (2021). Ethan Coen: *Jerry Lee Lewis: Trouble in Mind* (2022, documentary); *Drive-Away Dolls* (2024) and *Honey Don't!* (2025), both written with Tricia Cooke.

WRITINGS BY ETHAN COEN

Gates of Eden (stories, 1998); *The Drunken Driver Has the Right of Way* (poems, 2001); plays including *Almost an Evening* (2008), *Offices* (2009), *Happy Hour* (2011), and *Women or Nothing* (2012).

KEYWORDS

Coen brothers; Joel Coen; Ethan Coen; film-philosophy; numismatic theology; political theology; theodicy; contingency; chance; tychism; agapism; Charles Sanders Peirce; Ludwig Wittgenstein; rule-following; private language; MacGuffin; sovereignty; katechon; Carl Schmitt; aleatory sovereignty; homo sacer; Leibniz; monadology; anti-detective fiction; neo-noir; Western; screwball comedy; Hollywood satire; pastiche; kenosis; tzimtzum; Lurianic Kabbalah; Book of Job; Ecclesiastes; hester panim; Purim-shpil; Rashi; Maimonides; Gershom Scholem; Franz Kafka; schlemiel; Emmanuel Levinas; the face; the gift; counterfeit; Jacques Derrida; Marcel Mauss; fiat money; Bretton Woods; Pascal's wager; Boethius; Fortuna; Quentin Meillassoux; extro-science fiction; speculative fiction; Jorge Luis Borges; Herman Melville; Dashiell Hammett; Cormac McCarthy; Søren Kierkegaard; irony; indirect communication; Stanley Cavell; acknowledgment; Iris Murdoch; attention; American cinema.